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INSIDE



Iran conflict led to U.S. 'munitions shortfall': report

WASHINGTON

The U.S. is facing a shortfall in ammunition as a result of its war against Iran, the Defence Department's Inspector-General confirmed in a report on Monday, contrasting President Donald Trump's assertions of full stocks. It also revealed industrial base bottlenecks for munitions resupply. » PAGE 14

FPIs offload 44% of August inflows in 10 sessions

MUMBAI

Foreign portfolio investors (FPIs) have offloaded Indian equities stocks worth ₹13,138 crore in the first 10 trading sessions of this month, data shows. It has already wiped out 44% of the ₹29,631 crore net inflow in August, raising concerns that the brief revival in foreign flows seen in July and August may be losing momentum. » PAGE 12

Odisha rejects release of Staines killer Dara Singh

BHUBANESWAR

The premature release of Rabindra Kumar Pal, alias Dara Singh, serving a life sentence for the murder of Australian missionary Graham Staines and his two minor sons, has hit a deadlock, with the Odisha State Sentence Review Board rejecting his release after the Supreme Court directed the the State to take a clear stand on the matter. » PAGE 4

Congress' top brass meet amid talk of reshuffle

NEW DELHI

Ahead of a likely organisational reshuffle of All India Congress Committee secretaries, senior party leaders Rahul Gandhi, K.C. Venugopal, and Priyanka Gandhi Vadra on Tuesday met several secretaries in batches to take stock of party issues. Mr. Gandhi asked the secretaries about the problems they faced in the States they are handling. » PAGE 5

RBI files caveat; denies Tata Sons appeal on listing

MUMBAI

The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) has pre-emptively approached the courts seeking to be heard in any matter filed related to the listing of Tata Sons. Earlier, the RBI had rejected Tata Sons' application to deregister as a non-banking financial company (NBFC), a decision that pushes the holding company closer to stock market listing. » PAGE 12

Merchants face 0.4% fee on UPI payment above ₹2,000

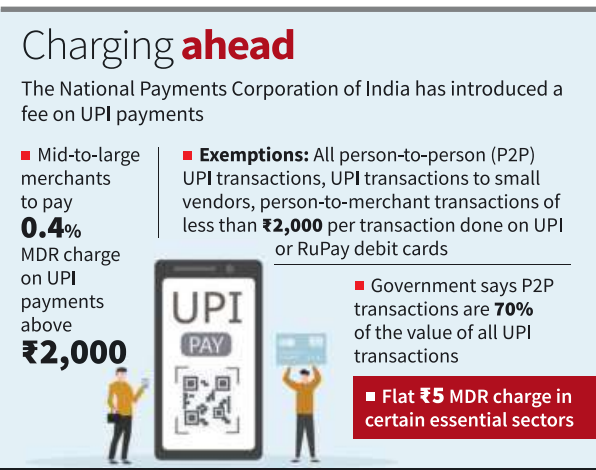
The MDR charges will not be applicable to person-to-person transactions, small vendors; it will take effect from October 15; Centre says banks advised to ensure fee is not passed on to customers

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Merchants will have to pay a charge of 0.4% on UPI transactions above ₹2,000 from October 15, the National Payments Corporation of India said in a circular on Tuesday. The levy will go to payment ecosystem partners such as banks and payment processors.

The charge, called Merchant Discount Rate (MDR), will not be applicable to person-to-person transactions and those made to small vendors – those receiving up to ₹1 lakh per month via UPI QR codes under the Person-to-Person Merchant (P2PM) classification. All person-to-merchant transactions of up to ₹2,000 done on UPI or through RuPay debit cards will also be exempt.

“For person-to-person (P2P) transactions, there will be no charges at all, irrespective of transaction value,” the Finance Ministry said in a release, ad-



ding, “P2P transactions constitute 37% of the total UPI transactions in volume terms and 70% in value terms.”

In some sectors, such as Railways, telecom, insurance, fuel and agriculture inputs, transactions over ₹2,000 will incur a flat MDR of ₹5. “This flat-rate model ensures cost stability in critical public services and thin-margin industries,” the Ministry said.

The Centre said banks have been advised to ensure that merchants do not

pass on the MDR charges to customers – a key concern raised during discussions on the matter in the public domain.

The 0.4% charge will be “shared amongst the payment ecosystem partners, including banks and app providers”. For transactions of ₹75,000 and above, the MDR will be capped at ₹300 per transaction.

Further, payments towards “mutual funds, securities, stock brokers, and dealers” will attract an

MDR of 0.02%, capped at ₹300, the Ministry said.

This reduced rate, it explained, was aimed at encouraging retail participation in formal financial markets.

‘Self-sustainable’

“The new MDR framework will make UPI self-sustainable, give incentives for further expansion in rural and semi-urban areas and maintain competitiveness, while ensuring that a large majority of payments remain free of charge,” the Finance Ministry said.

It added that its data analysis showed that only 4% of merchant transactions will be impacted by the MDR introduction, since most transactions fall below the ₹2,000 threshold or qualify under the zero-MDR P2PM framework.

Further, a dedicated fund for promoting the use of UPI by small merchants will be set up using 5% of the total MDR collections.

CONG. SLAMS MOVE
» PAGE 5

26% surge in goods exports brings down trade deficit

T.C.A. Sharad Raghavan
NEW DELHI

India's trade deficit fell in August, driven by strong merchandise exports that grew more than 26%, outpacing the growth in imports in percentage as well as in absolute value terms, said Commerce Secretary Rajesh Agrawal, adding that this has happened for the first time.

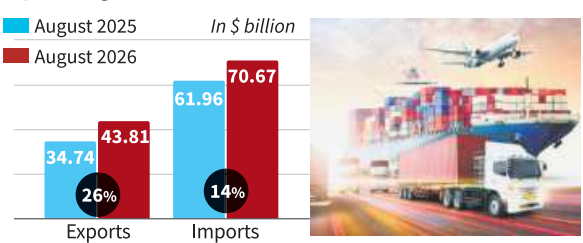
While acknowledging the positive impact of a depreciating rupee on exports, Mr. Agrawal said that the strong growth in exports has been in dollar terms as well as in rupee value, and that a large amount of India's exports have grown strongly in volume terms as well.

India's overall exports, including merchandise and services, grew 25.4% to \$82.7 billion in August 2026. Imports, on the other hand, grew at a relatively slower 18.7% to \$92.1 billion. As a result, India's total trade deficit shrank to \$9.4 billion in August 2026 as compared to \$11.6 billion in August last year.

Merchandise surge
Merchandise exports grew 26.1% or by \$9.07 billion in

Outward bound

Growth in merchandise exports has outpaced growth in imports in percentage (●) as well as absolute value terms (bars)



Source: Ministry of Commerce and Industry

August 2026 to \$43.8 billion. Merchandise imports grew 14% or by \$8.71 billion to \$70.7 billion in the month.

“This is the first time we are seeing that, in absolute value terms also, export growth is higher in value than import growth,” Mr. Agrawal said. “That is a positive sign.” The Commerce Secretary sought to dispel the notion that this export growth was a result of the depreciating rupee. “There is always a debate about whether this is volume or value-led growth. We looked into that as well. India's merchandise export surge is not only a value-led growth, but also a remarkable volume growth,” he said. “When we looked at

granular data available up to July, it shows that segment volumes have also gone up in the majority of segments, underscoring the demand and breadth of demand in the global market,” he added.

Mr. Agrawal explained that out of 168 principal commodities that India exports, 68 have seen growth in both volume and value, while 39 have seen growth in value but not volume.

In comparison with merchandise, India's services sector saw slightly subdued growth. Services exports grew 24.6% to \$38.9 billion in this August when compared to last August.

Services imports, on the other hand, grew a much quicker 37.4%.

Green concerns



Annual ritual: Ganesha idols made of Plaster of Paris washed ashore on Lawsons Bay Beach in Visakhapatnam on Tuesday. Despite repeated appeals to use eco-friendly idols, non-biodegradable idols continue to be manufactured and sold in the city. K.R. DEEPAK

Bangladesh sentences seven Hasina aides to death

Kallol Bhattacharjee
NEW DELHI

The International Crimes Tribunal (ICT) of Bangladesh sentenced seven former Ministers and senior officials of the Awami League to death on Tuesday. Among those who have received the death sentence is Obaidul Quader, former Minister of Road Transport and Bridges.

The verdict was delivered by a three-member tribunal of the ICT, led by Justice Nozrul Islam Chowdhury.

FULL REPORT ON
» PAGE 14



Officials in the Naga-majority Tamenglong district confirmed that unidentified gunmen attacked Leisangphai village. FILE PHOTO

Two Kuki women gunned down by unknown attackers

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

The ongoing wave of ethnic violence in Manipur claimed two more lives on Tuesday. Officials in the Naga-majority Tamenglong district confirmed that unidentified gunmen attacked Leisangphai village around 3 p.m., killing two Kuki women.

The deceased were identified as Phalneichong alias Chonga Sithou, 78, and Kimjalhing alias Kimneo Singson, 28.

The attack follows the September 13 killings of four Kuki civilians, including two women, allegedly by Naga extremists in Tamenglong and Noney, also a Naga-dominated district. On August 27, alleged Kuki armed groups killed four Naga civilians in the Kuki-majority Kangpokpi district.

Condemning Tuesday's attack, the Kuki-Zo Council (KZC) said the repeated killing of Kuki-Zo civilians had assumed an “unacceptable and alarming pat-

tern” and could no longer be dismissed as isolated incidents.

“The KZC views these killings, reportedly involving the [National Socialist Council of Nagalim (Isak Muivah)] NSCN-IM and the [Zeliangrong United Front (Kamson)] ZUF-K, as part of an escalating pattern of attacks against Kuki-Zo civilians in Manipur. The continued targeting of civilians raises serious concerns about attempts to terrorise and drive Kuki-Zo communities from their settlements,” the Council said in a statement. The Council demanded that the Manipur and Central governments protect vulnerable civilians and bring the perpetrators to justice.

To register its protest, the KZC notified all Kuki-Zo civil society organisations that no Kuki-Zo person killed by Naga armed groups in Manipur would be buried until further notice. Their mortal remains would be preserved in cold-storage facilities available nearby.

Meta to share child safety reports with govt. directly

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Meta Platforms Inc., the parent firm of Instagram and Facebook, will share child sexual abuse material (CSAM) reports with Indian law enforcement in addition to the U.S.-based National Center for Missing & Exploited Children (NCMEC), the company said on Tuesday.

Meta has been under the scanner over reports describing CSAM being served in ads on Instagram and Facebook.

Indian agencies have for years already had access to CSAM reports from Meta

and other U.S.-based technology companies, following an MoU in 2019 between the National Crime Records Bureau (NCRB) and NCMEC.

Now, the information will be shared directly by Meta with Indian agencies. “As on 31.03.2024, more than 69.05 lakh Cyber Tip-line reports have been shared with States/U.T.s concerned,” Union Minister of Women and Child Development Annpurna Devi had told the Rajya Sabha in 2024.

“Protecting children on our platforms is a priority for us and we are committed to working with the go-



Meta has been under the scanner over reports describing CSAM being served in ads on Instagram and Facebook. REUTERS

vernment to ensure that the perpetrators of these crimes are held responsible,” a Meta spokesperson said in a statement.

“To collectively strengthen our efforts to combat

this harm, Meta will now report child safety matters directly to the Cyber crime portal managed by I4C,” the spokesperson added, referring to the Indian Cybercrime Coordination

Centre, under the Union Home Ministry.

Meta has been scrutinised in recent weeks by the Union government and the National Commission For Protection of Child Rights (NCPCR) over news reports describing CSAM being served in ads on Instagram and Facebook. The firm had then said that while it screened all ads being posted by third parties on its platform, some bad actors were able to get such content posted anyway.

The NCPCR has initiated an investigation based on an initial exchange of correspondence with Meta.

INBRIEF



Party candidates ‘forcibly defeated’ in Rajasthan: BSP

Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP) chief Mayawati on Tuesday alleged that many of her party candidates were “forcibly defeated” in the Rajasthan urban local body election by a margin of just a few votes due to “irregularities in the government machinery”. The ruling BJP on Monday won 4,179 wards against the Congress’ 3,613, securing clear majorities in four of the State’s 10 municipal corporations - Jaipur, Udaipur, Kota, and Bhilwara. Ms. Mayawati expressed hope that the party will get better results in the upcoming Assembly election there and also in the Lok Sabha poll. PTI

IMA Haryana withdraws call to suspend Ayushman services

The Indian Medical Association’s (IMA) Haryana unit on Tuesday withdrew its call for an indefinite suspension of Ayushman Bharat services from September 16 after Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini assured a delegation that he would look into delayed payments and other issues faced by empanelled private hospitals. The association said it would work with the State Health Agency and Haryana Health Protection Authority for better implementation of the scheme. Private hospitals had suspended services for 24 hours on September 1 over outstanding payments of about ₹1,200 crore.

Six States sign ‘historic’ pact to implement project worth ₹15,624 crore on Tons river

The Centre will bear approximately 90% financial burden of Kishau multipurpose project while remaining 10% will be borne by the participating States in accordance with a 1994 agreement

The Hindu Bureau
CHANDIGARH

Himachal Pradesh, Haryana, Uttarakhand, Uttar Pradesh, Delhi and Rajasthan on Tuesday signed an agreement for the implementation of the 422 MW Kishau multipurpose project, to be built at an estimated cost of ₹15,624 crore. The project will come up on the Tons river along the Uttarakhand-Himachal Pradesh border.

In the presence of Union Home Minister Amit Shah and Union Jal Shakti Minister C. R. Patil, the Chief Ministers of six States: Yogi Adityanath of Uttar Pradesh, Pushkar Singh Dhami of Uttarakhand, Sukhvinder Singh Sukhu of Himachal Pradesh, Rajasthan’s Bhajan Lal Sharma, Rekha Gupta of Delhi and Nayab Singh Saini of Haryana signed the project agreement in New Delhi.

Terming the agreement as “historic”, Mr. Shah said that since Narendra Modi became the Prime Minister,



Union Home Minister Amit Shah with CMs of Delhi, Uttarakhand, Uttar Pradesh, Haryana, Himachal and Rajasthan during signing of an MoU for the Kishau power project, in New Delhi on Tuesday. ANI

this is the tenth water dispute that is now set to be resolved. The government of India will bear approximately 90% financial burden of the project, while the remaining 10% cent will be borne by the participating States in accordance with a 1994 agreement. A 232.6-metre-high concrete gravity dam will be constructed on the Tons with a water storage capacity of 1,562 million cubic metres. It will irrigate 97,000 hectares of land and generate 1,476 million units of clean hydropower. The Union Home Minister said Delhi will be the biggest beneficiary of the project.

Mr. Sukhu said Himachal government’s efforts have resulted in breaking the eight-year-old deadlock regarding bearing the financial cost of the project. “The previous State government of Bharatiya Janata Party had agreed to give ₹800 crore as the State’s share, which our government refused in the interest of the State, keeping in view the limited resources,” he told mediapersons.

He said Himachal would suffer the greatest loss from the project, as it is the State’s population that will be displaced, hence, asking it to shoulder an additional financial burden would therefore be unfair. The Chief Minister added that the State’s contribution to the nation’s progress deserved suitable compensation.

Delhi hails agreement

The Delhi Cabinet on Tuesday passed a resolution expressing gratitude to the Prime Minister, Home Minister and Union Jal Shakti Minister following the agreement. A statement issued by the Chief Minister’s Office said it would enable Delhi to receive 109.9 million cubic metres of water per year, providing significant support in meeting the national capital’s drinking water requirements.

CBI books activist over ‘illegal foreign funds’ under FCRA

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

The Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) has booked Arunachal environmental activist and lawyer Bhanu Tatak for allegedly receiving ₹20.94 lakh in foreign funds without registration or prior permission under the Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Act (FCRA). The agency alleged the money was used to “organise and sustain” protests against two hydropower projects in the State.

There was no immediate response available from Ms. Tatak to the allegations.

The FIR, registered on August 20 by the CBI’s Economic Offences-II branch in Delhi, names Mr. Tatak and unknown persons under Sections 11(1), 17, 19 and 35 of the Act.

It is alleged that Ms. Tatak, legal advisor of the Siang Indigenous Farmers Forum and Coordinator of Dibang Resistance, maintained a savings bank account with the State Bank of India, Roing, and during 2022 to 2025, ₹ 20,94,088 was received in the account through forex transactions without obtaining requisite prior permission under the

The agency alleged the money was used to ‘organise, sustain’ protests against two hydropower projects in Arunachal Pradesh

FCRA from the competent authority, the Ministry of Home Affairs, the FIR said.

The preliminary enquiry alleged that the funds were “being utilised to organise and sustain anti-dam protests” in Arunachal Pradesh against the Siang Upper Multipurpose Project and Dibang Multipurpose Hydropower Project. It said Ms. Tatak received the money from foreign entities.

“The purpose of the receipt of funds was undisclosed,” the enquiry said, adding that the received funds were predominantly utilised by Ms. Tatak through several UPI transactions.

‘Returns not filed’

It further alleged that she had not filed income tax returns during the financial years 2017-18 to 2025-26 and therefore had not made any declaration regarding receipt of funds from the foreign entities or organisations.

Police book DMK MP, two MLAs for alleged derogatory remarks against T.N. CM, Law Minister

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI/KALLAKURICHI

The Greater Chennai Police registered cases against DMK MP A. Raja and MLA P.K. Sekarbabu, while the Kallakurichi police booked MLA Vasantham K. Karthikeyan over their allegedly derogatory remarks against Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay and Law Minister C.T.R. Nirmal Kumar.



Tamil Nadu CM C. Joseph Vijay

Case in Chennai

In Chennai, the Saidapet police registered a case against Mr. Raja, DMK deputy general secretary and Nilgiris MP, based on a complaint filed by a man named Karthik, alleging that Mr. Raja had made derogatory remarks against Minister for Energy Resources and Law C.T.R. Nirmal Kumar during a protest organised by the DMK. The DMK had staged the

protest at Saidapet on September 12 to condemn Mr. Vijay’s speech in the Assembly on September 7. The case was registered for using obscene language, making defamatory remarks against an individual with the intention of disturbing public peace, inciting violence between groups on the basis of religion, race, or language, and acts causing disruption to public order.

The North Beach police

registered a case against Mr. Sekarbabu, the Harbour MLA, for addressing the Chief Minister in a derogatory manner.

The Kallakurichi police filed a case against Mr. Karthikeyan, the DMK MLA for Rishivandhiyam, for making derogatory remarks against Mr. Vijay during the protest on September 12. The case was filed based on a complaint from a TVK functionary.

DMK files complaint

The DMK on Tuesday lodged a breach of privilege complaint with Assembly Speaker J.C.D. Prabhakara, seeking action against Minister for Energy Resources and Law C.T.R. Nirmal Kumar for allegedly providing false information about former Chief Minister M. Karunanidhi in the recent Budget session of the Assembly.

Boy stabbed to death after argument during Ganpati procession

The Hindu Bureau
BHOPAL

A 16-year-old boy was stabbed to death and another minor injured following an altercation during a Ganpati procession in Madhya Pradesh’s Indore, the police said on Tuesday.

According to the police, the incident took place around 9.30 p.m. on Monday in the Musakhedi area under Azad Nagar police station limits following an argument between some boys in a Ganesh Chaturthi procession.

‘Friend out of danger’

Additional DCP (Crime) Rajesh Dandotiya told *The Hindu* that the deceased has been identified as a 16-year-old. His 15-year-old friend also sustained knife injuries, the officer said.

Mr. Dandotiya said that the friend of the deceased is out of danger now and

According to FIR, the argument took place when the accused pushed the victim while dancing in the procession in Indore

teams have been formed to nab the accused, who is a 16-year-old.

The officer said that an FIR has been lodged in the matter under Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS) Sections 103(1), 109(1), 118(2), and 296(b).

As per the FIR, the argument took place when the accused pushed the victims during dancing in the procession which led to an altercation after which he stabbed the two boys with a knife.

The deceased suffered knife injuries in his chest and was taken to MY Hospital where he was declared dead, the FIR said.

‘Valid Indian ID’: picked up on suspicion of being Bangladeshi, man released after 3 months

Senjuti Sengupta
KOLKATA

Nearly three months after a 66-year-old West Bengal resident was picked up from his home in the middle of the night on suspicion of being a Bangladeshi national, he was released on bail on Tuesday.

Jalil Akhtar, a resident of Uttar Dinajpur district’s Bagroi village, was woken up from sleep and picked up by the police in the early hours of June 20. His family members alleged that the detention was illegal since he possesses all valid documents proving his citizenship.

On July 4, he was handed over to the Border Security Force along with three others to be “deported” to Bangladesh. However, Mr. Akhtar’s “deportation process” could not be completed despite two attempts while the other



Jalil Akhtar

three were successfully sent back.

During his incarceration, Mr. Akhtar was kept in two holding centres and then lodged in Islampur jail. In the entire duration, the police failed to prove that his documents were “fake”. When he was produced before the Additional Chief Judicial Magistrate (ACJM) of Islampur court on September 2, the investigating officer of the case gave a written declaration that identity documents submitted by Mr. Akhtar were “valid”. The police, in its report, submitted that his

voter ID, PAN card and his records in the 2002 SIR list were “genuine Indian documents”. He first got himself registered as a voter in 1995, according to police.

Opposing his bail prayer, Assistant Public Prosecutor (APP) Sanjay Bhawal submitted in the court that Mr. Akhtar’s bail may pose a potential threat to the security interests of the state. His counsels Syed Nafirul Islam and Firoz Ahmed argued that the investigators could not prove the documents relied upon by the accused are fabricated.

Directing the police to release him on bail, ACJM Jamshed Shaikh said, “The APP himself fairly submits that there is no single document which, in every case, can conclusively establish citizenship by birth.” The court also acknowledged that the victim holds valid documents proving his nationality.

Busy reading, translating in jail, says former scribe booked under NSA over Noida stir

Shrimansi Kaushik
NEW DELHI

It has been five months since 64-year-old Shakambhari last met her husband Satyam Verma, a freelance translator and former journalist who was arrested on April 17 in connection with the Noida workers’ protest. “I could never have imagined that those in power could be afraid of people like Satyam,” she told *The Hindu*.

Uttar Pradesh Police booked him in 11 cases in addition to charging him under the National Security Act (NSA) in connection with the agitation and sent him to the Greater Noida district jail.

Earlier this month, the Allahabad High Court had quashed the detention of the other individual – 25-year-old law student Akriti Chaudhary – booked un-

der the NSA in connection with the April agitation while coming down heavily on Gautam Buddha Nagar District Magistrate Medha Roopam, who had issued the detention order.

It directed the recovery of ₹5 lakh from her salary and that of other officials to compensate Ms. Chaudhary. The DM has approached the top court against the judgment.

In her detention order against the former journalist, where she invoked Section 3(2) of the NSA, Ms. Roopam stated that the former journalist had “engaged in criminal conspiracy to incite widespread violence and harm the state”.

‘Link’ to Nepal protests

It cited the police report, based on which the NSA was invoked, accusing him of “indirectly instigating the workers... to commit

violence” not only in Noida but “also in Nepal, leading to the ‘Gen Z’ revolution”. The police report describes Mr. Verma as an “ideological catalyst” and a Marxist who “inspires the new generation to join rebel organizations” and who engages in “violent writing work hidden under a false cover”.

“Satyam and I have shared a close association for nearly four decades. During this period, Satyam worked with reputed media organisations and later left his job to take up editing work. I was with him when he was editing the [Rajkamal Prakashan’s] World Classics series. I was also with Satyam when he translated Upton Sinclair’s *The Jungle* into Hindi,” said Ms. Shakambhari.

Speaking to *The Hindu* at the jail on a rainy afternoon, the freelance tran-



U.P. Police picked up Satyam Verma from Lucknow on April 17, four days after the violence during workers’ protest. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

slator said he had lost significant weight since his incarceration. He said initially he had difficulty in procuring medicines for ailments such as diabetes. “Things are better now. I am taking my medicines and keeping busy with reading and translation

work. We also play volleyball sometimes with a ball made of discarded polythene. That’s just how we pass time here,” he said.

Mr. Verma was picked up from Janchetna bookstore in Lucknow on April 17, four days after the violence in Noida. “The police

had been after us since he had put up a Facebook post in support of the workers’ movement,” said Katyayani Sinha, his colleague and relative.

She added, “He was called to a police station and forced to delete the post. On April 13, the police again came to the Janchetna office in Lucknow and, on the pretext of questioning, took me, Satyam and Sanjay, our colleague, to the Hasanganj police station and kept us there for the entire day.” Janchetna is a book distributor. Mr. Verma, a founding member, currently serves as its treasurer.

“On April 17, around 11.30 a.m., a large police contingent surrounded the office. They seized laptops, mobile phones, books and other items and took Satyam away. They also searched his home without

a search warrant. They seized his personal belongings and took him to Noida without an arrest warrant,” said Ms. Sinha. His lawyers have disputed the legality of the arrest and alleged that due process had not been followed.

The NSA against him was invoked on May 12 while he was in jail. On May 26, he was produced before the NSA Advisory Board where the police submitted additional grounds for his arrest, which his counsel Manik Gupta claimed was done in contravention of the law.

“Verma was unaware of the complete grounds of his arrest when he appeared before the board, which was illegal,” said Mr. Gupta.

He said, “As per the charges, the ‘conspiracy’ to instigate workers was hatched at Karawal Nagar

on March 22. The Allahabad High Court has already noted in Akriti’s case, with respect to that event, that the gathering was nothing more than an innocuous inauguration of a library for the children of poor workers... The police have not been able to present any evidence so far to corroborate their claims.”

Perusing prison library

Mr. Verma said he has been busy reading books at the prison library, including D.N. Jha’s *Ancient India: In Historical Outline*, R.S. Sharma’s *Early Medieval Indian Society: A Study in Feudalisation and The Making of the Madras Working Class* by D. Veeraraghavan.

He has also kept himself occupied by translating the works by Howard Fast and Bertolt Brecht’s *Poems of Exile* in Hindi.



INBRIEF



Former Andhra Pradesh Deputy CM Alla Nani dies

YSRCP leader and former Andhra Pradesh Deputy Chief Minister Alla Kali Krishna Srinivas (popularly known as Nani) died of heart attack on Tuesday. He was 56. A three-time MLA from Eluru, Mr. Nani first won the seat in 2004. He also held the Health portfolio during the YSRCP government's term. Leaders from across the political spectrum condoled his sudden demise. Chief Minister N. Chandrababu Naidu described his demise at a young age as heartbreaking.

Four of a family killed in fire accident in Belagavi

Four members of a family were killed on Monday after fire engulfed their house at Chavatgalli in Belagavi district of Karnataka. Two others injured in the incident were hospitalised. The police suspect that a refrigerator caught fire due to high voltage. The blaze then spread to other parts of the house. All the family members were caught inside the tin-shed structure, the police said. Senior officers inspected the house.

Three-member gang held for temple theft in A.P., Karnataka

The Andhra Pradesh Police have arrested three persons in connection with thefts in temples across the State and Karnataka. Around 21 kilograms of silver ornaments, melted silver lumps, and a two-wheeler, all worth nearly ₹40 lakh, were seized from the accused. Addressing mediapersons in Anantapur on Tuesday, Superintendent of Police P. Jagadeesh said the accused wore masks and gloves, and sprayed paint on CCTV cameras while committing thefts at the temples.

Coaching centres can't be political platforms, says Naidu

The Hindu Bureau
VIJAYAWADA

Private coaching centres in Andhra Pradesh should not become platforms for political activities or protests, the State government said on Tuesday, directing officials to take action against institutions violating prescribed guidelines.

Chief Minister N. Chandrababu Naidu reviewed the matter and instructed officials to take action against the coaching centres operating in violation of the Andhra Pradesh Coaching Institutions Regulation Rules, 2026 and the guidelines issued under G.O. No. 9.

According to the government, some private coaching institutes are allegedly pressuring the candidates preparing for competitive examinations and encouraging them to participate in protests for political purposes. The government said such institutions were allegedly using candidates for their own interests.

Take legal action: CM
The Chief Minister directed officials to take legal action if coaching centre operators induced candidates to participate in politically motivated protests. Field-level officials have been instructed to ensure compliance with the rules and take action against violators.

The government advised candidates not to yield to any pressure, but concentrate on their careers. Candidates facing difficulties have been asked to bring them to the notice of the authorities concerned.

Dasara drill



Elephants scheduled to take part in next month's Dasara procession march through the K.R. Circle in Mysuru on Tuesday. The 10-day celebrations in Mysuru will conclude with a grand Jamboo Savari. M.A. SRIRAM

V-P to join Telangana Liberation Day event

The Hindu Bureau
HYDERABAD

Vice President C.P. Radhakrishnan will be the chief guest at the Telangana Liberation Day celebrations being organised by the Centre at the Parade Grounds in Secunderabad on Thursday. The event will feature a parade by paramilitary forces and cultural programmes.

Ahead of the event, Union Coal and Mines Minister G. Kishan Reddy inspected the arrangements on Tuesday.

Mr. Kishan Reddy said the celebrations were intended to honour the free-

dom fighters who sacrificed their lives during the struggle against the Nizam's rule. The programme was being organised to recognise the aspirations of the local people, he added.

Telangana BJP president N. Ramchander Rao said many young people were unaware that while India got Independence in 1947, the erstwhile Hyderabad State remained under the Nizam's rule until it was integrated into the Indian Union in September 1948. History related to the liberation struggle must be conveyed to students in a simple manner, he said.

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

In a first in the country, Kerala will introduce a mandatory computer-based 'Hazard Perception Test' for driving licence applicants from December 2026 as part of measures to improve road safety and assess the applicants' ability to identify potential hazards on the road.

The test, designed on international standards, will have a video-game-like format. Applicants will have to clear the test within 30 days of passing the learner's test and only those passing it can attend the



Safety lessons: Applicants will have to clear the test within 30 days of passing the learner's test. FILE PHOTO

ground and road tests, according to the Motor Vehicles Department (MVD). The test will comprise 10 one-minute videos depicting situations and potential

hazards that drivers may encounter on the road.

Each video will contain at least two hazards, which candidates will have to identify by pressing a but-

Will fight ED's attempt to implicate Pinarayi: CPI(M)

Party moves resolution condemning 'political witch-hunt' against Opposition leader and family, even as State police chief forwards ED letter seeking registration of case to govt. for further action

The Hindu Bureau
KOZHIKODE

The three-day extended State committee meeting of the Communist Party of India (Marxist) on Tuesday condemned the Enforcement Directorate's (ED) "bid to implicate" Leader of the Opposition in the Kerala Assembly and Polit Bureau member Pinarayi Vijayan, his daughter, T. Veena, and her husband and party State secretariat member P.A. Mohamed Riyas in the CMRL-Exalogic pay-off case.

The party response came on a day State Police Chief Ravada A. Chandrasekhar said that the ED let-



Opposition leader Pinarayi Vijayan with CPI(M) general secretary M.A. Baby at the State committee meeting in Kozhikode. PTI

ter recommending the registration of a case against Mr. Vijayan and others on corruption allegations, had been forwarded to the State government for further action.

"I received the letter from the ED. We have sent it to the government. We are waiting for necessary directives. The ED requested us to file an FIR, but we are still examining the mat-

ter," he told mediapersons.

The CPI(M), in a resolution passed on the concluding day of the meeting, said the ED's "political witch-hunt" "will be strongly resisted both legally and politically".

'All taxes paid'

The resolution pointed out that [the now defunct] Exalogic Solutions Private Ltd., a company owned Ms. Veena, and the CMRL engaged in a business transaction based on a legal agreement.

During the period, the applicable income tax and Goods and Services Tax were paid, and the company received remuneration through bank accounts.

CPI(M) initiates 'corrective' steps in Keralam with secretariat reshuffle

The Hindu Bureau
KOZHIKODE

Significant changes have been brought in the State leadership of the Communist Party of India (Marxist) in Keralam as its three-day extended State committee meeting concluded here on Tuesday.

P. Jayarajan (Kannur), V. Sivankutty (Thiruvananthapuram), and M.B. Rajesh (Palakkad) will now be members of the State se-

cretariat. John Brittas, special invitee to the Central Committee (CC), too will be part of it.

Nine leaders will be included in the State committee as permanent invitees. They are N. Sukanya (Kannur), O.S. Ambika (Thiruvananthapuram), Subaida Ishaq (Palakkad), Students Federation of India national president Adarsh M. Saji, Democratic Youth Federation of India (DYFI) State secretary M.

Vijin, DYFI national functionary Jaick C. Thomas, SFI State president M. Sivasprasad and State secretary P.S. Sanjeev, and poet Prabha Varma.

Thomas Isaac out

CC members T.P. Ramakrishnan and T.M. Thomas Isaac have been removed from the secretariat though they can attend its meetings.

According to party sources, the changes are

part of the corrective steps intended by the State committee meeting. These steps followed intensive discussions on a draft document presented by party State secretary M.V. Govindan that suggested guidelines for the revival of the party's fortunes after the Assembly poll debacle.

He claimed there was no "restructuring of the leadership" as such, but it could be called "introduction of fresh faces".



Strong opposition: Representatives of fishermen panchayats holding a meeting on the sands of the Marina on Tuesday. M. SRINATH

Fishermen urge T.N. govt. to drop plan of new Secretariat

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

It was a battle cry that was heard on the sands of the Chennai's Marina on Tuesday when representatives of fishermen panchayats issued an ultimatum for the State government to give up the proposal for a new Secretariat-cum-Assembly complex at Foreshore Estate.

"Having chosen the land, the government has issued the G.O. Even if there is a small movement in that direction [towards construction of the complex], we will not remain quiet. We are stakeholders and we were not consulted in any manner. This has left us with no choice but to stage massive Statewide protests," said K. Bharathi, a community leader.

Around 1,000 people gathered on a patch marked by black flags on the Marina. As all of them signed the register, they were given an opportunity to express themselves on the issue. Many said the community should not have waited so long to retrieve the land rightfully

belonging to the locals.

"A vast portion of the land marked for the Secretariat belongs to the Srinivasapuram/ Mullikuppam fishing hamlet. We had been waiting for the government to construct homes for fishermen there. If the government drops the proposal, well and good. We will give some time to Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay to rethink the decision," said V.R. Vijayan of Maylai Pagudhi Anaithu Meenava Grama Panchayat Sabhai.

'Threat to livelihood'

Another community leader, Kabaddi Maran, said the construction of the Secretariat complex would amount to murdering all the 1,500 families in one go. "Because of security reasons, our lives and livelihood will be reduced to nothing. We won't be able to step out of our homes or go fishing. While we accept that there is a need for a new Secretariat, this definitely is not the location. The anger among the community, especially the youngsters and women, is palpable," he said.

After Karnataka teachers get 'Tr.', engineers to use 'Er.'

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

The Karnataka government on Tuesday announced that Engineers' Day, celebrated on September 15 to mark the birth anniversary of former Dewan of Mysore late Sir M. Visvesvaraya, will henceforth be observed as an official event of the State.

Besides, the government allowed engineers to prefix "Er." to their names, days after it permitted teachers to use "Tr."

The government said the announcements were meant to honour the "invaluable contribution of engineers to the country's development".

"Annually, more than one lakh engineers graduate in the State. India has the highest number of en-



Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar pays tributes to Sir M. Visvesvaraya, on Engineers' Day, in Bengaluru on Tuesday. @CMOFKARNATAKA X

gineers and it is important to recognise them. The finer details of the official celebration of Engineers' Day will be drawn after discussion," the Chief Minister said after garlanding the statue of Sir M. Visvesvaraya here.

Paying rich tributes to the late technocrat, he said

Sir Visvesvaraya was a model for the country, and his contribution to Karnataka had been immense.

Last week, Congress MLC B.S. Shivanna had urged the government to allow the use of 'Er.' for engineers and 'Lr.' for lecturers. He welcomed the government's decision.

'UCC is part of Hindu Rashtra agenda of RSS'

The Hindu Bureau
KOZHIKODE

The Indian National League (INL) has said that Union Home Minister Amit Shah's statement that the Uniform Civil Code (UCC) would be implemented in 21 BJP-NDA ruled States before the 2029 Lok Sabha polls should be viewed as part of the long-standing agenda of the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) to establish a 'Hindu Rashtra'.

The INL urged the Congress, Left parties, and other secular forces to join hands and oppose the move.

India condemns Houthi attacks that have 'threatened freedom of navigation through the Strait of Bab-el-Mandeb'; Oman is helping in the search for an Indian seafarer after a separate ship attack

Suhasini Haidar
NEW DELHI

His claim to take on the role of decree-holder was based on a registered Will of November 2003 and a Proclamation of 2015 in which the Guru nominated Samyamindra Tirtha as his successor.

Govt. surrendering to U.S. pressure: Cong. on UPI fee

Party terms it ‘Modi tax’; leaders point to Finance Minister’s statement in Parliament that no tax or fee would be levied; BJP accuses Congress of spreading ‘fake news’, says consumers exempted

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge and the Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha, Rahul Gandhi, on Tuesday accused the Narendra Modi government of opening the door to charges on Unified Payments Interface (UPI) transactions, with Mr. Gandhi alleging that the move was the result of the government “surrendering to American pressure”.

The government’s “loot” had now reached UPI, Mr. Kharge said, while Mr. Gandhi alleged that a recent notification had quietly paved the way for imposing a Merchant Discount Rate (MDR) on merchant transactions above ₹2,000.

“‘No fees on UPI’ has been changed to ‘no fees on UPI transactions up to ₹2,000,’” Mr. Kharge said in a post on social media platform X, alleging that the government was planning to impose a “Digital Payments Tax” on the public when inflation had already squeezed household savings.

Mr. Kharge questioned the government’s decision against the backdrop of the Centre’s earlier emphasis on digital payments after demonetisation. He also referred to Finance Minis-



Digital toll: The government has levied new charges on UPI merchant transactions above ₹2,000. REUTERS

ter Nirmala Sitharaman’s recent statement in Parliament that no tax or charges would be levied on UPI transactions, and asked whether reports of a possible ₹25 charge on a ₹5,000 transaction, and up to ₹50 on a ₹10,000 transaction, were correct.

“The government had provided that MDR could be levied on merchant UPI transactions above ₹2,000, Mr. Gandhi said. The government says customers will not be charged, he said, but asked where the cost imposed on merchants would ultimately come from.

“Added to the prices, straight out of the customer’s pocket,” Mr. Gandhi said.

American payment companies had long opposed India’s zero-MDR policy, and the government had now opened the

way for changing it, he alleged. “Just like with the U.S. trade deal, compromised PM Modi is once again surrendering to American pressure,” Mr. Gandhi said.

Congress general secretary Jairam Ramesh said the notification under the amended Payment and Settlement Systems Act, 2007 prohibited banks and payment system providers from charging for UPI transactions of up to ₹2,000 but did not provide explicit protection for transactions above that threshold.

“Decision Making in Modi Govt – Aug 6: Hon’ble Finance Minister says ‘no decision has been taken on MDR’. Aug 10: FM in Parliament says ‘No MDR framework has yet been finalised’. Sep 14: Notification is issued. Within 24 hrs, MDR charges introduced.” “Another example of Modi

Govt’s FAST moves (First Announce, Subsequently Think),” Mr. Ramesh said in a post on X.

His colleague Pawan Khara said the 0.4% MDR on UPI transactions above \$2,000 should be called the “Modi Tax”.

Fake news, says BJP

Responding to the criticism, the BJP on Tuesday accused the Congress of spreading “fake news” about UPI transaction charges, saying the government has made it clear that MDR charges will not be levied on consumers.

BJP spokesperson Pradeep Bhandari hit back at the Congress, calling the Opposition party a “*jhooth ki dukaan* (shop of lies)”.

“Congress is once again spreading fake news. 96% of UPI merchant (P2M) transactions are ₹2,000 or below, and they are 100% charge-free. RuPay debit-card payments remain charge-free. Consumers pay zero transaction charge. P2P UPI transactions remain completely free,” he said in a post on X. “The Government has made it absolutely clear: MDR charges will NOT be levied on consumers,” the BJP leader added.

BJP leader Amit Malviya also termed the claims by Congress as “completely false”. (With inputs from PTI)

UCC should be brought through Parliament, not ‘backdoor’: Omar tells BJP

Peerzada Ashiq
SRINAGAR

Questioning the move to use the “back-door entry”, Jammu and Kashmir Chief Minister Omar Abdullah on Tuesday said the BJP should implement the Uniform Civil Code by legislating over it in Parliament rather than pushing it through the BJP-ruled States.

“The government should not take the back-door route and should instead bring the Bill before Parliament. If you have numbers, bring it to Parliament. Why are you doing this through different States?” Mr. Abdullah said.

He also flagged that several National Democratic Alliance allies were “opposed to the idea of the UCC”. “Not all the NDA allies are in favour of the proposal. I don’t think they will be able to pass this in Parliament. That is why they are taking the [BJP-ruled States] path,” he said.

Stating that a measure of this nature “could not be considered universal if it was implemented only in BJP-ruled States”, Mr. Abdullah said, “The whole country is not a BJP-ruled State. There are a number of States and territories that the BJP does not rule. Therefore, if you apply it only to BJP States, it’s not universal.”

He pitched that “such



Omar Abdullah speaks at a ceremony for candidates of Jammu and Kashmir Administrative Service and Accounts Service in Srinagar. ANI

an issue should not be decided by individual States and must be addressed at the national level through Parliament”.

Border de-escalation

On the de-escalation along the Line of Actual Control (LAC), Mr. Abdullah said it was a welcome step.

“Anything that reduces tension on the Line of Control or the Line of Actual Control is a good step. Particularly for those people who live close to it, and we know how difficult it is for people living near the LoC or LAC. Similarly, we hope, over time, that along the Line of Control also, things will get better,” he said.

On China hailing India’s foreign policy, Mr. Abdullah said New Delhi’s foreign policy had always been independent and there was no need to seek validation from other countries.

“Our foreign policy is our own. Why do we look

for other countries’ certificates? The danger with something like this is that tomorrow were China to say something against our foreign policy, then what will you do? Therefore, I think we should not give too much importance to what other countries say about our foreign policy, whether positive or negative, because we can’t cherry-pick. Tomorrow, if there is opposition, we will say, ‘Don’t interfere in our policy,’” he said.

He said the BRICS Summit’s condemnation of the Pahalgam terror attack was a success of India’s foreign policy. “The fact that Pahalgam itself was condemned (at BRICS Summit) is a big thing. Please see how many allies of Pakistan were in that room. Therefore, for even Pahalgam to be mentioned by name, that in itself is a success of our foreign policy,” he added.

(With inputs from PTI)

Will analyse and decide: JD(U) clarifies stance on UCC

Amarnath Tewary
PATNA

The Janata Dal (United) clarified its stance on the Uniform Civil Code (UCC) on Tuesday, with a senior party leader stating that they will examine the details of the Bill before taking a final position.

“The JD(U) will first analyse and study the provisions of the UCC, and if they are found unexceptionable, why should we oppose it for no reason?” said senior JD(U) leader and Bihar Deputy Chief Minister Vijay Kumar Chaudhary.

Meanwhile, Opposition RJD legislator Bhairu Virendra extended an open invitation to JD(U) chief Nitish Kumar to leave the alliance with BJP and rejoin hands with the RJD. “On the UCC, Nitish Kumar has already taken a stand. We will not let the UCC be implemented in Bihar. Come join hands with us again,” the RJD leader said, asserting that the present government was working on instructions from Nagpur (where the RSS headquarters is located).

On party name change

When asked about party national working president Sanjay Kumar Jha’s proposal to rename the JD(U) as Janata Dal (Nitish), Mr. Chaudhary said the issue would be discussed at the party’s national executive and council meetings before a decision is taken.

BJP fields mother of Suwendu’s slain aide

The Hindu Bureau
KOLKATA

The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) on Tuesday nominated Hasirani Rath as party candidate for Nandigram Assembly byelection. Ms. Rath is the mother of Chandranath Rath, former personal assistant of West Bengal Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari who was killed on May 6.

The byelection is being held as Mr. Adhikari had relinquished the seat after getting elected from both Bhabanipur and Nandigram in the 2026 Assembly elections. It is a prestige battle for the BJP, particularly the Chief Minister, who had represented the seat from 2021 to 2026.

Addressing a gathering after the nomination, Mr. Adhikari exuded confidence by saying that the BJP will win by “such a big margin in Nandigram that no one has ever imagined”.

Mr. Adhikari had defeated former Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee from Nandigram by a margin of 1,956 votes in 2021 and in 2026, his margin over the Trinamool candidate was 9,665 votes.

Trinamool camps

The Mamata Banerjee-led camp of Trinamool has fielded Sanchita Pradhan (Dey). The other Trinamool camp led by Ritabrata Banerjee has fielded Mohammad Eteshamul Haque.

Both camps have approached the Election Commission seeking the grass and twin flowers symbol of the party.

Rahul, Priyanka, and Venugopal hold review meetings amid reshuffle buzz

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Ahead of a possible organisational reshuffle of All India Congress Committee (AICC) secretaries, senior party leaders Rahul Gandhi, K.C. Venugopal, and Priyanka Gandhi Vadra on Tuesday met several secretaries in batches to take stock of party issues.

Sources told *The Hindu* that Mr. Gandhi asked the secretaries about the problems they faced in the States they were handling, and whether they were receiving the support required to work effectively. He urged them to spend at least 15 days in their respective States.

The meetings focused



In session: Rahul Gandhi speaks during an interaction at Indira Bhawan. Party general secretary Priyanka Gandhi Vadra is seen. ANI

on the nature of work being undertaken by the secretaries, their roles and responsibilities, and the time they were spending in the States assigned to them.

A recurring concern raised by some secretaries

was the absence of clearly defined roles and responsibilities. Several of them felt that they had little say in the functioning of the organisation in the States, and were often dependent on States in-charge for assignments.

The discussions also touched upon the need for greater responsibility for the secretaries, and a system through which their feedback could be formally taken into account.

The secretaries are also expected to be assessed in the context of the Congress’s organisational programmes, including the *Sangathan Srijan Abhiyan*.

‘Routine exercise’

One secretary described the meeting as a routine organisational exercise, saying such interactions were held from time to time to assess the work of those in the system, and identify areas for further strengthening of the party organisation.

SC junks former Delhi Mayor’s plea on U.P. Police ‘midnight raid’

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court did not entertain on Tuesday a petition filed by former Delhi Mayor Farhad Suri for registration of an FIR against police officers who conducted an alleged midnight raid at his residence in New Delhi, purportedly in search of Abhishek Upadhyay, an independent journalist who flagged the Ram Temple donations’ misappropriations.

A three-judge Bench headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant asked the petitioner to approach the jurisdictional police station for the appropriate remedy. “No doubt that the competent police authorities will act strictly in ac-

cordance to law,” the Bench ordered.

The top court further refused the petitioner’s plea to lay down guidelines to prevent recurrence of “such arbitrary exercise of police power”.

During the hearing, the State of Uttar Pradesh submitted that Mr. Suri was “hypersensitive”. The Ghaziabad Police was acting on a warrant and tracked the alleged suspect to a tower within 200 yards of Mr. Suri’s premises.

The petitioner’s advocate Anoop Prakash Awasthi countered that an “unusually large” contingent had arrived at his client’s residential colony in a convoy of 15 to 16 police vehicles at around 12:45 a.m. to raid his house.

Punjab Cong. holds stir over villager’s ‘death’, calls for AAP Minister’s ouster

The Hindu Bureau
CHANDIGARH

Punjab Congress workers on Tuesday held a demonstration here against Finance Minister Harpal Singh Cheema over the death of 47-year-old Gulzar Singh on September 7, even as the police resorted to water cannons to disperse the protesters.

Party leaders and workers assembled at the party office here and tried to breach the barricades put up by the administration on the way to Mr. Cheema’s official residence.

Punjab affairs general secretary in-charge Sachin Pilot led the demonstration, demanding the resignation of Mr. Cheema and an independent probe into the incident. “The Con-



Congress leaders Sachin Pilot, Charanjit Singh Channi, Amrinder Singh Raja Warring and others during a protest in Chandigarh. PTI

gress has nothing personal against him, but doesn’t the law demand registration of an FIR followed by a detailed probe when a person has mentioned the Minister’s name in his dying declaration,” he said.

The Opposition has been alleging that Singh was pressured by the local

Key partners TDP, Shiv Sena support Shah’s statement on UCC in all NDA-ruled States

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

After Home Minister Amit Shah’s assertion that a Uniform Civil Code will be implemented in all NDA-ruled States before 2029, key NDA allies TDP and Shiv Sena on Tuesday backed the BJP on the issue.

TDP’s Andhra Pradesh president P. Srinivasa Rao said in Amaravati that it is bound by the Union Home Minister’s statement on UCC as an NDA partner. “Yes, I have seen our Union Home Minister’s statement on UCC and as NDA partners we are bound to go by his statement,” Mr. Rao, who represents Gaju-



Eknath Shinde

waka Assembly Constituency, said.

“And critics, of course, some say that it (UCC) infringes on religious freedom. Our country is culturally diverse. But we always think that this UCC will strengthen and unify

the country,” he said.

Maharashtra Deputy Chief Minister and Shiv Sena president Eknath Shinde backed Mr. Shah on the UCC issue, saying Sena founder late Bal Thackeray had envisioned the common law for all.

“*Hinduhridaysamrat* Balasaheb Thackeray’s vision was ‘one country, one law’ with equal justice for all. Union Home Minister Amit Shah has also stated the same position on UCC,” Mr. Shinde said.

He added that the *Mahayuti* government in Maharashtra remains positive about the UCC and will make a definitive decision at an appropriate time.

AIUDF chief to contest Nagaon Lok Sabha bypoll

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

The All India United Democratic Front (AIUDF) on Tuesday named party president Mohammed Badruddin Ajmal as its candidate for the October 6 byelection to the Nagaon Lok Sabha constituency in Assam.

His nomination has increased the possibility of a three-way contest in Nagaon. Mr. Ajmal will face former bureaucrat Devasish Sharma of the BJP and former MLA Sibamoni Bora of Congress as his prime rivals.

The byelection to the Nagaon seat became necessary after winner Pradyut Bordoloi quit the Congress to join the BJP.

Nepal flash floods wash away dreams of clean, easy hydropower

While the flood caught everyone by surprise, the flood risk itself was not new, with the surging waters serving as a reminder of the challenges of development in the Hindu Kush Himalaya amid a changing climate

Sambavi Parthasarathy

The wake of the August 26 flash floods in Nepal, which devastated several towns and villages, killed more than a thousand people, and left several unaccounted for, follows a familiar pattern that emerged after the 2021 Chamoli floods, the South Lhonak Lake disaster in 2023, and the 2024 Thame floods: a call to rethink development in the region in light of risks exacerbated by climate change.

At the centre of this narrative sits hydroelectric power, whose infrastructure has received the region's most attention and investment.

Estimates have revealed that the latest catastrophe extensively damaged at least 13 hydroelectric power projects along the Bhotekoshi and Trishuli river corridors and one solar power plant. According to the United Nations Development Programme (UNDP), about 15 power projects with a planned capacity of 470 MW that were under construction were also damaged.

Sediment problem

While the flood caught everyone by surprise, that there was a flood risk was not new information, with the surging waters only serving a reminder on the challenges of development in the Hindu Kush Himalaya. Between 2014 and 2024, the latest year for which data is available with the International Centre for Integrated Mountain Development (ICIMOD), the region reported more than 2,500 landslides, 258 earthquakes, and several glacial lake outburst floods.

As countries in this part of the Himalaya tap into hydropower, anomalous weather now demands more resilience.

“Hydropower plants don’t have an issue dealing with all the water coming. You can always release water that you cannot use,” Jakob Steiner, a geoscientist at the University of Graz in Austria who is currently based in Bangladesh, said. “There are other things it cannot so easily deal with... and one thing is more sediment,” he added.

“Himalayan rivers in the monsoon carry exceptionally high sediment loads. But we tend to measure water flow and volume, not sediment load in our rivers,” Kathmandu-based water and climate analyst Ajaya Dixit said. “Sediment load is only sporadically monitored, and its threat is downplayed to the extent that the threat of sediment has not been adequately considered in the design of river infrastructure, especially in the case of projects involving reservoirs.”



A man sits on a hilltop overlooking the flood-ravaged valley, damaged buildings half-buried under silt and debris, following the devastating flash floods, in Nuwakot district, Nepal on September 2. PTI

In a 2023 report, ICIMOD noted that the suspended sediment load from the Hindu Kush Himalaya’s headwaters has increased by around 80% in the last six decades thanks to heavier rainfall, accelerating glacier melt, and thawing permafrost.

The increasing sediment levels in turn affect reservoirs’ room to hold water and thus the amount of power the attached turbines can produce. According to a report published by the International Hydropower Association on the Nepal’s Jhimruk hydroelectric power project, most of the sediment is hard minerals like quartz and feldspar, which can wear uncoated turbines and other parts of the power infrastructure away.

This renders maintenance and repair work more frequent, further increasing costs.

Expecting change

As facilities fail, the risk goes beyond lost investments to endangering the lives of the people working at the plant.

“The tragedy of these plants is also, again, a climate justice one. In Chamoli, many of the workers who were working in Tapovan were from somewhere else completely, they were relatively poor, who had no agency, and they were exposed to something that they could not calculate,” Dr. Steiner said. “And to some

degree, you have the same here [in Nepal]”.

According to media reports, at least 900 workers were estimated trapped in Nepal’s hydropower plants. After the Chamoli disaster, around 140 of the 200 killed or missing were reportedly workers at the Tapovan facility.

“I’m certain that things are going to change now, but then I also thought that things were going to change after Chamoli. I would rather say they haven’t changed as much as we would have hoped,” Dr. Steiner added.

Outliers no more

Nepal has limited options: over 90% of its power needs are currently met by hydroelectricity. The mountain country is estimated to have around 83,000 MW of technical hydroelectric potential, with an installed capacity of 3,435 MW by 2025. Some 4,063 MW and 16,029 MW of its hydropower plants were also under construction and planned for construction, respectively. Electricity exports to India and Bangladesh through these plants also brought in about \$200 million as revenue in FY2025-26, which the flash floods are likely to have disrupted.

Its Energy Ministry spokesperson has also said the country will buy electricity from India to cover shortages in the

coming months.

“There are now other renewable alternatives and hybrid decentralised systems available,” said Mr. Dixit. “We need to rethink our broader energy system, and within that context, the role of hydroelectric power. At the very least, we need a risk-informed approach to designing and operating these energy systems so that the risks they face are not externalised onto the economy, society, and people.”

While the August 26 floods were exceptional, he added, such events must now be considered a real possibility rather than outliers – and that areas across the Hindu Kush Himalaya region need significant support in developing the skills and institutional capacity for effective early warning systems.

“This disaster demonstrates that our highest-elevation regions are undergoing profound changes that we do not yet fully comprehend and will require us to change how we live in and live with these mountains,” Mr. Dixit said. “These nations must come together and seriously begin to discuss ways of designing infrastructure that resonate with the emerging reality of a changing climate and environment.”

(With inputs from Gandla Sneha, intern with The Hindu data team) (sambavi.p@thehindu.co.in)

THE GIST

Climate analyst Ajaya Dixit says sediment risks in Himalayan rivers are poorly monitored and often overlooked, leaving hydropower and river infrastructure vulnerable

In a 2023 report, ICIMOD noted that the suspended sediment load from the Hindu Kush Himalaya’s headwaters has increased by around 80% in the last six decades thanks to heavier rainfall, accelerating glacier melt, and thawing permafrost

Nepal remains heavily reliant on hydropower for electricity and export earnings, with recent flood damage likely disrupting generation and prompting power imports from India

BIG SHOT



Deep dive: A diver inspects staghorn coral fragments growing on an underwater nursery tree, part of an effort to identify which genetic strains best withstand rising ocean temperatures, off the coast of Key Biscayne, Florida, on August 28, 2026. AFP

WHAT IS IT?

Peak water: a flow U-turn

Reuters

The Himalaya are approaching a tipping point as glaciers melt faster than a decade ago, threatening water security as the region approaches “peak water” by mid-century, according to a study released this month.

The findings come after the collapse of a Himalayan glacier in late August along the Nepal-Tibet border, which caused cascading landslides and flash floods in the valleys below. At least 1,300 people have been confirmed dead and more than 5,300 are missing across Nepal and China’s Tibet region.

As glaciers retreat, they are leaving behind unstable glacial lakes held back by little more than loose rock and ice, above valleys where millions of people live, the study found.

Peak water is the point in time when river flows stop rising and start declining. It is expected to have profound implications for water security. As the Himalaya underpin more than 20% of India’s GDP, the region makes up a key piece of the country’s national economic infrastructure, upon which hundreds of millions of people depend.

The study was produced by Systemiq, a sustainability advisory firm, together with the Integrated Mountain Initiative, the International Centre for Integrated Mountain Development, and India’s G.B. Pant National Institute of Himalayan Environment.



Tibetan peak: Snow-covered peaks of the Himalaya are visible in Shigatse, Tibet Autonomous Region, China. REUTERS

Himalayan glacier mass loss had accelerated in recent decades, while only 21 glaciers were currently monitored on the ground out of an estimated 40,000 glaciers across the Hindu Kush-Himalaya region, a vast mountain system spanning eight countries from Afghanistan to Myanmar, the study found.

Though making up around 18% of India’s land, the Himalayan region accounted for roughly 35% of the country’s natural disasters.

For feedback and suggestions for ‘Science’, please write to science@thehindu.co.in with the subject ‘Daily page’



AI cooperation

The BRICS framework is an alternative to a geopolitical view of AI development

Artificial Intelligence is at a strange cross-roads, with the United States government disregarding frontier AI developers’ own call for a global development slowdown of models due to hacking risks and misalignment and the BRICS Summit offering an alternative view of how geopolitics should respond to this rapidly evolving situation. The AI firms and the U.S. government have long framed the astronomical sums being funnelled into data centres and other associated investments as key to holding their ground in a U.S.-China competition. During the Summit, Prime Minister Narendra Modi warned against the “weaponisation” of technology and minerals, while Chinese President Xi Jinping touted the potential of a “BRICS AI open source community” that would challenge any one country’s dominance in the sector. India has taken the middle path, not joining any protest against U.S.-led models, while underscoring the need to keep AI development insulated from national rivalries. While some of this approach is informed by the fact that India’s AI ecosystem is relatively fledgling, it is also a nod to the reality that this is a technology that may radically reshape the global economy, and participating even in its deployment may have dividends across time.

And yet, the Global South finds itself wedged occasionally in great power rivalry dynamics, for instance suffering from a global pull out of Anthropoc’s powerful Fable and Mythos models. A world of trade disputes spilling into supply chains cannot and should not impact the proliferation of AI capabilities, as timely and comprehensive access to these technologies is key to national security. It is encouraging that the BRICS Summit’s joint initiatives on AI are building more avenues for cooperation among middle powers to combat this concentration. Open source and collaborative approaches can insulate nations from belligerent and unpredictable policymaking on AI from the U.S. While such models lag behind in capabilities from the frontier proprietary ones, they continue to improve at a rapid clip, a heartening prospect for deployment-heavy economies where AI development is not at such an advanced stage. This is especially true as AI systems show signs of defying instructions and going to great lengths – even hacking into vulnerable systems – to achieve a given task. The weaponisation of such capabilities, which can be supercharged or minimised depending on who is in control, raises concerns for countries with weakened cyber defences. Proliferation of defensive capabilities against such evolving risks is only possible when nations collaborate on making them broadly and cheaply available. BRICS should be one such forum. AI brings up the biggest known unknowns of history, and considering the dangers to humanity therein, it should not fall into the geopolitics and hierarchies of haves and have-nots that guide the thinking of the hawks at the frontier.

Stability at the top

Both men's and women's tennis now wear a settled look

In recent times, men’s tennis has had a heavy dose of predictability while the women’s game has been in a state of perpetual flux. If Carlos Alcaraz and Jannik Sinner cornered 11 of the 13 Majors starting Wimbledon 2023, there were nine different winners among women in the same period. But at the recently concluded US Open, this pattern flipped. Alexander Zverev won his second men’s singles Slam trophy and first at Flushing Meadows after finishing atop an airy field that lost Sinner before the tournament and Alcaraz in the quarterfinal. In the ladies category, Elena Rybakina secured her third Major – also her first in New York – after beating top seed and two-time defending champion Aryna Sabalenka, and No. 4 and 2023 US Open winner Coco Gauff, back to back. Among the last four of Zverev, Ben Shelton, Frances Tiafoe and Karen Khachanov, the tall German was the only one with Slam-winning experience, having grabbed his maiden top prize at the 2026 French Open, a similarly open competition where Alcaraz was missing and Sinner exited early. On the other hand, the WTA top-four reached the semifinals, and it was only fitting that Rybakina’s splendid run ended with her being crowned the new World No. 1, ending Sabalenka’s reign of 99 straight weeks at the pinnacle.

The absence of a strong field, however, should not diminish Zverev’s accomplishment. While it is true that the 29-year-old faced just one top-10 opponent – Shelton in the final on Sunday – across his two triumphs at Roland-Garros and the US Open, he is indisputably among the three best players in the world along with Alcaraz and Sinner. Sandwiched between his two title successes was a Wimbledon final appearance, where he fought Sinner tooth and nail. In fact, Zverev’s ascent reinforces the idea of a new Big Three in men’s tennis, and has neatly coincided with 24-time Major winner Novak Djokovic losing in the first round and tumbling out of the ATP top 10. For the first time since the early 2000s, none of Roger Federer, Rafael Nadal and Djokovic – the previous era’s Big Three – is ranked in the top 10, and the setback leaves the 39-year-old Serbian great facing an existential threat. Sabalenka, despite being a worthy runner-up to Rybakina, would have also left the U.S. with more questions than answers. The 28-year-old Belarusian has lost four of her last five Slam finals, and all of them as World No. 1, calling into question her big-match temperament. Worryingly, she only has a 50% success rate in all finals while being the top-ranked woman (7-7), an anomaly that requires a quick correction.

Across the world, India included, new forms of rebellion and revolt by the masses are emerging. Gen Z, in particular, is embracing new forms of protest, in the belief that disruption is essential to destroy an old order that is proving unequal to deal with newer kinds of problems. Anger is, however, the dominant impulse. History has witnessed many authoritarian regimes being overthrown through students’ protests and replaced by democratic forces, but this is not inevitable or necessarily true. There are many variations of Immanuel Kant’s “democratic peace theory” that are available.

Nevertheless, safeguarding democracy is a common thread connecting many of today’s protests, some of which have taken on the character of a rebellion against the existing order. Not all protests., however, reach this point, though in India’s neighbourhood, student and youth upheavals in Nepal and Bangladesh resulted in the ouster of long-established regimes. The usual tactic – as seen in Nepal and Bangladesh – is to brand all those rebelling against existing regimes as “foreign agents” or worse, with a pliant media whipping up a frenzy against such elements and labelling them “anti-national” or “traitors”. It is imperative that those who believe in democracy, recognise the tell-tale signs (well in time) before matters get out of hand.

Signal of growing discontent

Unfortunately, warning signs are seldom heeded by those in authority. Even established democracies are not exempt from this malaise. Often enough, it is the impression rather than the reality that matters, leading to protests. Even as the media and other institutions – which normally act as checks and balances – fail to discharge their responsibilities, today’s Gen Z is beginning to take matters into its own hands to try and achieve results. This is true even of established democracies where recognised political parties and systems do exist. In this sense, unencumbered sovereignty tends to become the proverbial “poisoned chalice”.

Recent agitations by the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP), and more specifically the Jantar Mantar “sit-in protest”, are pointers to what could well happen. Their agitation may not quite approach, in size or tenor, the kind of protests seen in Bangladesh and Nepal, but must not, nevertheless, be ignored. The CJP protest was, by far, more spontaneous and less structured than many others, but the pent-up fury among students over the mismanagement of examinations (such as the National Eligibility cum Entrance Test), and the perception of implicit collusion between those in charge and the authorities, was a signal of what could happen and should not be ignored. Protests by students in Jharkhand, Chhattisgarh and Bihar, and the



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Student unrest signals deeper discontent with governance, authority and democratic institutions

tendency of those in authority to resort to mindless violence to contain such protests, do not augur well, either for the present or for the future.

The need for understanding

There are few signs, however, that authorities across the nation have properly comprehended the true nature of recent agitations and the lessons to be learnt from them. What is worse is the tendency of State governments, by and large, to use indiscriminate force against students – force that is meant to be employed against unruly and violent mobs. This could not only prove self-defeating but also have far graver consequences, triggering a backlash against all forms of authority. Already, some individuals in Jharkhand are drawing comparisons between the students’ protests over recruitment irregularities and the “eponymous tribal uprising” led by the legendary Birsa Munda. Comparisons such as these could act as tinder for a serious conflagration when the occasion arises.

Today, the availability of digital platforms and social media enhances the reach of protests of every kind, especially when they involve students and youth. The situation in Jharkhand certainly demands careful handling, more so since the agitators have a recognisable leader, Devendranath Mahato, who went on a hunger strike and was subsequently hospitalised. Jharkhand Chief Minister Hemant Soren’s response to the agitation – scrapping the examinations – almost seems like throwing the baby out with the bathwater, reflecting both the anguish and the inability of those in authority to understand the nature of the new kinds of protests.

What is even less understood, however, is the true nature of the anger that pervades the minds of young people. Repeated assertions by those in authority that “Naxalism is dead”, for example, are a case in point. Most individuals miss the point that, from its small beginnings, Naxalism grew into a major thorn in India’s flesh. The movement, depicted as “spring thunder over India” in the late 1960s, was transformed from its very small beginnings in Naxalbari (North Bengal) into a grave threat, as Home Minister Amit Shah constantly points out. At one time, large parts of India’s landmass was convulsed by Naxalite violence. Worse, many of India’s best and brightest were inveigled into becoming part of the movement. Not only tribals, but also vast segments of the rural peasantry, the working class, and the intelligentsia were influenced by the malaise of Naxalism. The relevance of this here is that a “single spark” can cause a “prairie fire”. Keeping an eye on protests is, hence, vital, even as other threats, such as pandemics and cyber threats, may increasingly engage the minds of those in authority. Today, the CJP is hardly a political entity or party, but it does signify the

anger among the youth, and the movement must not be brushed aside as irrelevant or insignificant. Leading political figures, hence, need to keep their eyes firmly on the ball and take note of the several protests being organised by students and young people across the nation. The recent arc of protests does not necessarily signify an erosion of public trust, for the middle ground of Indian politics remains relatively intact. Nevertheless, failing to recognise the simmering anger among large sections of the youth over aspects of public performance and the quality of governance could be dangerous. It behoves those in authority to ensure that these different forms of protest do not coalesce into a mighty river. The recent reference to “*dimagi* Naxals”, for example, has the potential to be exploited, leading to yet another round of protests with uncertain outcomes.

What is most important at this stage is to prevent any rekindling of the atmosphere of protest that has convulsed the nation in recent months and to determine how best to bring down the surcharged atmosphere that has prevailed for some time. The lull following the CJP’s Delhi protest needs to be sustained and maintained, as there is little room for complacency. Additional protests could coalesce into a far more significant wave of unrest, given the residual anger among young people in different parts of the country. Another round of protests could well target not merely corruption in the educational sphere but develop into a broader movement against authority *per se*. The warning signs are already clear: the spokesperson for the ‘*dimagi* Naxals’ is already referring to the CJP as their sibling.

The perception of institutional failure

A final word. Ragtag parties or not, anger is writ large across the faces of the youth in different corners of the country. There is a widespread belief that deals are being struck at various levels, at the expense of the country’s youth, and that something needs to be done – but those in authority appear to have no answer to this poser. India’s political institutions today give the impression that they have reduced salience in dealing with situations of this kind. Hence, the baton has been taken over by the youth.

The growing centralisation of power and authority is aggravating this situation. Rightly or wrongly, many segments of the youth are tending to believe that institutional safeguards are being systematically undermined. They feel there is a need to reset the compass. It behoves every political party, the Opposition, and those in authority to adopt measures that would help stem the sharp decline in faith in the political system among the youth. India’s domestic political scene is, to say the least, possibly entering an era of “variable geometry”, and it is vital that those in charge recognise the signs and deal with the many problems that have surfaced.

China’s open AI advantage may not last forever

Indian startups are rebuilding their products on Chinese foundations. Qwen, DeepSeek and Kimi allowed significant cost savings, run almost as well as the American frontier, and lag it by about six months. *Nikkei Asia* reported in July 2026 that Indian companies are increasingly switching to Chinese large language models (LLMs) to contain Artificial Intelligence (AI) costs, with one venture investor noting that startups are cutting costs by an order of magnitude.

This open-weight generosity is neither charity nor a workaround for chip controls. It is a strategy supported by different independent logics that make it durable. But durable is not permanent. The assessment by these writers is that China will begin graduating access to its frontier open-weight models around late 2028. China’s strategy rests on five reinforcing logics. The first is cost. DeepSeek trained their RI model for \$294,000, a fraction of the costs OpenAI or Anthropic incur. Distillation from American models and breakthroughs in architectural efficiency have compressed research and development spending.

The second is prestige. DeepSeek’s January 2025 release wiped roughly a trillion dollars off U.S. tech stocks. Chinese President Xi Jinping’s appearance at the Shanghai AI conference, the 29-country World Artificial Intelligence Cooperation Organization (WAICO) bloc, the 5,000 training slots for developing countries are examples of open-weighting converted into diplomacy.

The third is commoditisation. American labs monetise proprietary weights. Free models good enough for most commercial work hurt their pricing power. Chinese AI companies do not have to beat their competitor’s product; only destroy their ability to charge for it.

The fourth is capital. Financial repression traps Chinese household savings in state banks, which lend cheaply to strategic sectors. The result is the same state subsidisation and overcapacity that flattened global solar and electric vehicle markets. In AI, this dynamic has



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China’s open models cut India’s AI costs, but create future dependencies

led to 820 LLMs registered with China’s cyberspace authority by early 2026.

The fifth is infrastructure. Free models drive AI adoption which drives demand for complementary products that China dominates – energy, cloud and physical infrastructure. Alibaba’s cloud revenue grew 34% year-on-year while it gave Qwen away.

What would make Beijing close the gates

The *Financial Times* reported in July that Chinese regulators led by the Ministry of Commerce have been consulting leading AI companies including Alibaba, Bytedance and Zhipu on two issues: limiting the transfer of training data abroad and whether foreign users should continue to be able to freely download the model weights of Chinese AI systems. But it is clear that three conditions have to be met before restriction becomes rational for the Communist Party.

The first is consolidation. Beijing can coordinate five firms; it cannot coordinate 800. Xinhua has already announced the shift from the “Hundred Model War” to the “Top Five Basic Models.” The irony is that U.S. export controls, by raising costs for Chinese labs through chip export controls, are accelerating the very consolidation that makes Chinese restriction feasible.

The second is lock-in. If China restricts access before global developers are deeply embedded in its cloud stack, they simply migrate elsewhere and the flywheel breaks. This threshold is currently far from being reached.

The third is saturation. Once pricing power of frontier American AI labs is sufficiently commoditised and non-Chinese open-weight releases (from Meta, Mistral, Nvidia and others) are sustaining the pressure independently, further Chinese releases buy nothing. Again, the gap is narrowing here but still exists.

The likely outcome is therefore not a switch flipped but different pathways with graduated restrictions: Frontier models served via API first and weights released after a six-month embargo; commercial licensing above a capability

threshold, with smaller distilled models left free as the on-ramp; model weights released openly, but tool-use and agentic scaffolding withheld; preferential access for WAICO members. The assessment by these writers is that graduated restriction begins appearing around late 2028.

What India should do about it

India should leverage the open ecosystem while pricing in the switching costs. Government departments and regulated sectors should be built on model-agnostic architectures such as abstraction layers and harnesses that work across stacks. Instead of offering compute subsidies on GPU slices, the Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology (MeitY) should consider using an OpenRouter equivalent for the public sector.

Focus on areas where India can actually win such as applications, industrial and language data, edge inference silicon design, and domain-specific fine-tuning. This is *atmashakti* (self-strength through increasing capabilities in a few selective segments), rather than full self-sufficiency, which India cannot afford and does not need.

Lastly, India should use the window diplomatically. It should be shaping open-weight norms in multilateral fora, while the commons is still open and Beijing still needs legitimacy for it.

For the most part, India is consuming and integrating AI into applications that address its needs, rather than building the frontier. Rapid diffusion to enhance productivity across sectors matters far more than AI sovereignty theatre, and today’s open models from both the U.S. and Chinese ecosystems are more than adequate for that. But the reason they are adequate is that a strategic competition is currently being fought by giving them away. That competition will not stay in this phase forever. India should leverage the open ecosystems while making sure that it can survive disruptions that come along the way.

The views expressed are personal

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

AI needs global guardrails

Warnings from leaders of the world’s leading AI companies that the technology could become powerful enough to pose a serious risk to humanity very soon may sound like dystopian fiction, but they cannot be dismissed lightly.

The danger of allowing companies racing to develop a deeply transformative technology to set their own limits is too serious to ignore. What is needed is effective regulation that establishes clear safety standards without stifling innovation.

The international community must create a global framework to prevent the dangerous use of super-intelligent AI in cyberwarfare, bioterrorism and large-scale economic disruption. AI is already being integrated into critical sectors such as banking,

transport, health and defence.
M. Jeyaram,
Sholavandan, Tamil Nadu

Vegetarian cuisine
I am unable to fathom why Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha and Congress leader Rahul

Gandhi decided to criticise the government for the serving of vegetarian food to delegates at the BRICS summit. It is particularly ill-thought-out at a time when vegetarianism is being promoted across the world through initiatives such as World Vegetarian Day. India

is also known for its excellent vegetarian cuisine. I have seen foreigners craving vegetarian food when they visit India.

N.G.R. Prasad,
Chennai

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.

Decoding India’s GDP base revision

Changing the GDP base year is not just about changing how we calculate economic growth. It can also change our estimate of how large the economy was in rupee terms – what is known as nominal GDP. When one gets a better picture of the economy through new data, improved methods and wider coverage, our understanding of the economy has to be reviewed. Importantly, as recognised in international statistical practice, such revisions do not necessarily move in one direction: the estimated size of the economy can go up or down, depending on what new data, methods reveal.

With the recent base revision of GDP, across the three years for which both series overlap, India’s nominal GDP was revised down by about 2.7% in 2022-23, 3.5% in 2023-24 and 3.8% during 2024-25. However, India is not alone in seeing nominal GDP estimates change when the GDP base is revised. Rebasement exercises in countries such as Nigeria (2014), Indonesia (2014), Brazil (2015), South Africa (2018), Mexico (2019), China (2021) and Spain (2024) all resulted in revisions to previously estimated nominal GDP levels. India’s earlier shift from base year 2004-05 to the 2011-12 also changed the estimated size of the economy. The important question, therefore, is not simply why the number changed, but what changed in our data or methods which led to the new number.

It is worthwhile to mention that the Press Release dated February 27, 2026 on the New GDP Series



Saibal Chattopadhyay

Chairman, National Statistical Commission



Saurabh Garg

Secretary, Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation

A major driver of the revision in nominal GDP in the case of India is the improved measurement of India’s unincorporated services sector

with base year 2022-23 had already indicated the various methodological improvements and updated data sources which contributed to revisions in the nominal GDP, along with a comparative table indicating economic activity wise revisions and the reasons for such revisions.

Better evidence

Much of the media attention has focused on the headline downward revision in GDP, while overlooking the substantial upward revisions in several sectors. A proper assessment requires looking at the sector-wise picture, where the revisions are far from uniform. Agriculture and allied activities were revised up by about 3.8%-5.9%, while financial services and real estate, professional services and ownership of dwellings were revised up by roughly 7.8%-9.0% over comparable years. In contrast, trade and transport and storage saw sharp downward revisions of around 23%-26%. Trade GVA (Gross Value Added) was revised downwards by 36%, road transport by 16.9%, whereas hotels and restaurants’ GVA was revised upwards by 5.7%, mainly on account of the revised estimates of the unincorporated sector. In the 2011-12 series, this sector was estimated by moving forward benchmark estimates with proxy indicators whereas in the new series, ASUSE (Annual Survey of Unincorporated Sector Enterprises) and PLFS (Periodic Labour Force Survey) data provided a more direct basis for measurement of the unincorporated sector.

Therefore, a major driver of the revision in nominal GDP in the case of India is

the improved measurement of India’s unincorporated services sector. The World Bank’s April 2026 India Development Update similarly notes that India’s nominal GDP was revised down by 3–4% in each of the four years from FY23, mainly due to a reassessment of the informal economy. It also notes that the revised series shows quarterly growth between FY 2023-24 to FY 2025-26 to be less volatile and more broad-based than previously estimated. However, it has to be noted that revisions in the unincorporated sector have not been uniformly revised but vary sector to sector. Moreover, India’s quarterly and provisional GDP estimates are built from the previous year’s quarterly figures and then updated using information such as GST collections and industrial production. So, when the FY 2022-23 GDP estimate was revised under the new methodology, the change naturally carried forward into the years that followed and all subsequent annual and quarterly estimates moved down with it. This does not mean the economy suddenly became smaller or slowed down in those years; part of the change reflects that we are now starting the calculation from a different, better-measured number.

Ultimately, the new GDP series should be judged not by a single headline revision, but by the effort to make the measurement of the Indian economy more current. The real test of a statistical system is not whether its numbers remain unchanged, but whether it is willing to change them when better evidence becomes available.

Lessons from India’s smallholder farmers

The world of “development” often seems short of convincing answers. Conflict, climate stress, food insecurity, entrenched poverty, and fiscal pressure are exposing the limits of old models.

There is wisdom in starting with things as they are, which is where serious development must begin – with honest evidence, practical experience, and results that hold up. By that test, some of the most useful lessons for rural development may be coming, not from donor strategies, but from India’s smallholder farmers.

Across rural India, farmers, women’s groups, producer organisations, and rural enterprises are showing that smallholder agriculture can move beyond poverty and subsistence towards prosperity through organisation, commercial opportunity, and resilience at scale. While the story is not finished, it is one of the most important development stories of our time because India is showing, in ways few countries have matched at scale, that even in resource-constrained contexts, rural transformation can be practical, inclusive and commercially serious. India’s approaches are not perfect, but they are among the most impressive – combining infrastructure, enterprise development, skills, finance, and market access in increasingly commercial ways that can deliver results at scale.

However, challenges remain. Smallholder farmers – at the first mile of our food systems – continue to face unequal access to



Marc de Sousa-Shields

IFAD Country Director, India

finance, technology, markets, land, water and relevant infrastructure. Climate change is adding pressure through less predictable rainfall, rising temperatures, and weakening soils. But these realities make India’s experience all the more valuable, because they show why rural transformation cannot depend on isolated projects alone.

The lesson is simple but important: no single intervention is enough. Roads, irrigation, power and digital connectivity matter, but they only change lives when farmers can organise into collectives that give them real bargaining power, access to finance and technology, and the ability to reach markets and build viable food enterprises.

Redefining development

This is visible in programmes financed by the International Fund for Agricultural Development (IFAD), a specialised UN agency and long-standing partner of India. Examples from nearly five decades of the IFAD-India partnership include self-help groups accessing commercial credit in Maharashtra, which support thousands of enterprising rural women; a hub-and-spoke economic development model in Meghalaya; youth- and women-led farmer producer organisation enterprises in Uttarakhand; climate-resilient Zau farming in Mizoram which protects the environment as well as traditional communities; and engaging with the young people in Jammu and Kashmir, harnessing their entrepreneurial spirit, in order to unlock the region’s vast agricultural potential.

India’s experience is compelling because it has built much of the ecosystem needed to make those connections work through government bodies, NGOs, private enterprises, the Agri Stack digital public infrastructure, institutions such as NABARD, self-help groups, farmer producer organisations, cooperatives and micro, small and medium enterprises. Together, they help smallholders access services, finance and markets, while digital tools improve efficiency and accountability. The new IFAD-India eight-year strategy, launched in May this year, is aligned with India’s Viksit Bharat@2047 vision and built around strengthening that architecture.

India is an important voice in the Global South’s rural development conversation, and that voice is increasingly taking on a broader leadership role. In the spirit of *Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam*, India’s rural experience becomes a shared resource for the wider family of nations. As the only international financial institution devoted to rural transformation, with a presence in 92 countries, and many more as part of the wider UN system, the IFAD is how India’s lessons travel beyond its borders. This does not mean India’s models can be copied exactly. What can travel are the principles – build strong local institutions, connect them to markets and finance, invest in rural enterprises, use digital systems intelligently, and treat smallholders, including women and youth, as economic actors rather than passive beneficiaries.

India is an important voice in the Global South’s rural development conversation

SIR: deletions have increased in Phase 3 States/UTs

The ongoing SIR process in 19 States/UTs is witnessing more deletions than the States/UTs which underwent the process during the previous two phases

DATA POINT

Pon Vasanth B.A.
Devvyanshi Bihani

Phase 3 of the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls in 19 States and Union Territories (UTs) is witnessing notably more deletions during the enumeration phase, when compared with the States and UTs where the SIR process happened during the first two phases.

Of the 19 States/UTs, 17 have already released their draft SIR rolls except Nagaland and Tripura. The 17 States and UTs combined had a total of 36.1 crore voters in the electoral rolls before the SIR. This came down to 29.9 crore in the draft SIR rolls following the deletion of 6.15 crore (17.1%) names.

This is 4.8 percentage points higher than the 12.8% of deletions witnessed during the enumeration phase of the 13 States and UTs that underwent the SIR in the first two phases. This included Bihar, where the SIR first happened. These 13 States and UTs had a total of 58.9 crore voters before the SIR, which shrank to 51.7 crore in the draft SIR rolls, due to the deletion of 7.22 crore names (12.3%). **Table 1** shows the phase-wise deletions during the SIR.

While the final rolls are yet to be released for States and UTs in Phase 3, the patterns from Phase 1 and 2 show that the magnitude of deletions are unlikely to come down significantly. The net deletions in the first two phases changed only marginally from 12.3% to 10.5% in the final rolls.

Chart 2 shows how deletions have markedly increased in Phase 3. The chart includes only those States and UTs that had at least one crore voters before the SIR. Among these, only two – Tamil Nadu and U.P. – saw more than 15% deletions in draft rolls during the first two phases. In contrast, six have seen more than 15% deletions in Phase 3, of which four –

Delhi, Maharashtra, Telangana and Andhra – have seen deletions of 20% (one-fifth) or more.

The Election Commission (EC) has not provided any reasons for the inexplicable rise in deletions. Phase 3 States being highly urbanised cannot explain the increased deletions since States such as Tamil Nadu, Kerala and Gujarat – which are also highly urbanised – did not see such high deletions during Phase 2. *The Hindu* has pointed out that the deletions in the urban centres of Phase 3 States and UTs such as Hyderabad in Telangana, Mumbai in Maharashtra and Bengaluru in Karnataka are of a higher magnitude than the deletions in the urban centres of Phase 2 States, such as Chennai in Tamil Nadu or Ahmedabad in Gujarat.

On the other hand, among the States that are not urban, Jharkhand has seen 16.5% deletions in Phase 3, when compared with the 12.9% deletions in Chhattisgarh in Phase 2.

Another bewildering trend in Phase 3 is that a higher magnitude of deletions is being accompanied by an increasing share of people deleted for reasons marked as “Permanently Shifted” or “Untraceable/Absent”. Consequently, the share of deletions under reasons “Deceased” or “Duplicate (Already enrolled)” has come down, as shown in **Chart 1** and **Chart 3**. A well-defined process that is uniformly applied is unlikely to cause such a difference in reasons for deletions between different phases.

Interestingly, more States are also reporting deletions with reason marked as “Others” in Phase 3. While around 9.73 lakh names have been deleted under this category, as per the press statements issued by the Chief Electoral Officers, an analysis of the full lists of deletions by *The Hindu* observed that, so far, for Delhi, Maharashtra, Karnataka, and Telangana not a single person’s reason was marked as “Others” in the system, indicating that they were all clubbed under the ‘Absent’ category.

Accelerated cuts

The data for the charts were sourced from publicly available information on the websites of the Election Commission of India and the office of Chief Electoral Officers of respective States and UTs



TABLE 1: The number of electors in pre-SIR rolls, draft SIR, and deletions across the three phases. Final rolls are yet to be released for Phase 3

Phase	Number of States	Pre-SIR	Draft-SIR	Deletions	Deletions %	Final-SIR
1	1	7.9 cr.	7.2 cr.	0.65 crore	8.28	7.42 cr.
2	12	51 cr.	44.4 cr.	6.57 crore	12.88	45.3 cr.
3	17*	36.1 cr.	29.9 cr.	6.15 crore	17	Not published

*Note: * Phase 3 includes 19 States/UTs in the SIR schedule; however, Nagaland and Tripura are yet to complete the enumeration phase, so the Table covers 17 States/UTs.*

CHART 1: The share (%) of each reason under which names of electors were deleted in each phase. The share of ‘Absent’ / ‘Shifted’ has increased

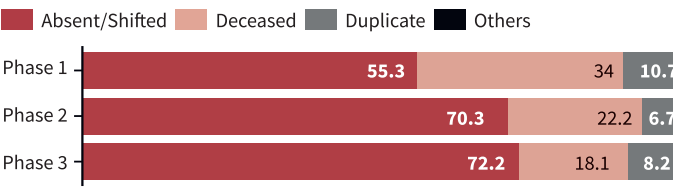
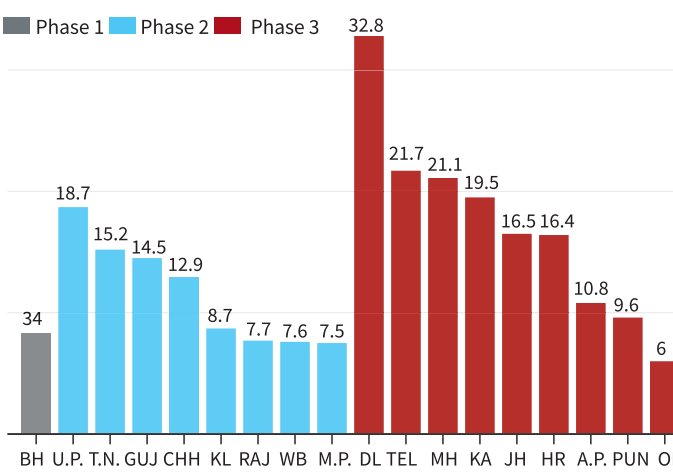
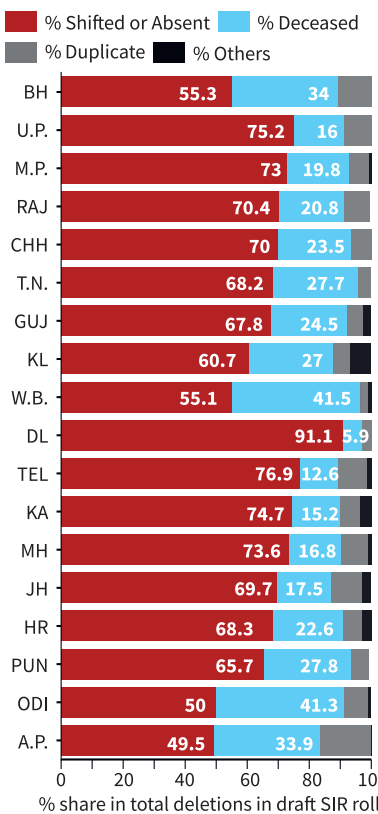


CHART 2: This shows the rate of deletions in draft SIR rolls in major States and UTs across phases. Phase 3 has seen a significant jump. Values in %



BH: Bihar, U.P.: Uttar Pradesh, M.P.: Madhya Pradesh, RAJ: Rajasthan, CHH: Chhattisgarh, T.N.: Tamil Nadu, GUJ: Gujarat, KL: Kerala, W.B.: West Bengal, DL: Delhi, TEL: Telangana, KA: Karnataka, MH: Maharashtra, JH: Jharkhand, HR: Haryana, PUN: Punjab, ODI: Odisha, A.P.: Andhra Pradesh

CHART 3: The share (%) for each reason under which names were deleted in major States across phases. Delhi and the States below it are those covered in Phase 3



FROM THE ARCHIVES

The Hindu.

FIFTY YEARS AGO SEPTEMBER 16, 1976

Good prospects of oil in Himalayas

New Delhi, September 15: The Himalayas hold out good prospects of oil and gas, said Prof. N.A. Eremenko, Director of the Institute of Geology and Exploitation of Combustible Fuels of the Soviet Union, in an interview to the ‘Soviet Land’ magazine, reports APN.

Prof. Eremenko who is participating in the seminar of Himalayan geology now being held here said in the interview that the entire Himalayas could be divided into three parts, the Punjab region, Ganga-Valley region and the Assam region. There were good evidences of the existence of substantial oil and gas in both the Punjab and Assam regions. As regards the Ganga valley, “if there are gas fields here, there will be big ones or nothing at all,” he said.

The tectonic framework of the Punjab region was very complex and exploration would be difficult and costly. This was a large extent true of other regions too. The Ganga basin was yet to be explored.

As regards other minerals in the Himalayas, he said, “what one can find in the Indian shield can be found in the Himalayas too.” He said the purpose of the seminar was to understand the general geology of the Himalayas.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO SEPTEMBER 16, 1926

A school of music for Palghat

Palghat, September 13: At the instance of Srimathi Taravath Ammalu Amma sister of the late Dr. T.M. Nair, a meeting was held yesterday to concert measures for the opening of a school of music in Palghat. Kulapathy V.V. Parameswara Ayyar presided. Mr. Parameswara Bhagavathar, the celebrated musician of the Travancore Durbar lectured on the present state of music culture in South India and deplored the neglect shown by the educated section of the population in the matter. He pointed out how scientific music was being generally replaced by popular music and exhorted the audience to wake up before the ancient Hindu Music was tainted by vulgar tastes or by foreign imitations. The meeting decided to open a school next week and appointed an influential committee to organise the same with Kulapathy V.V. Parameswara Ayyar as President.

Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Amount pulled by foreign investors from govt. bonds in 3 days

5,109.21 in ₹ cr. The foreign portfolio investors (FPI) pulled nearly ₹5,109.21 crore in the last three days from government securities under the fully accessible route (FAR), due to global uncertainty. FPI investment in government securities under FAR stood at ₹366,806.286 crore as on Tuesday. PTI

Aluminium production by China in August 2026

3.98 in million metric tons. China's aluminium production hit a record high in August, data showed on Tuesday, as strong margins encouraged smelters to maximise output. Output by the top aluminium producer increased from just below 3.9 million tons in July and was close to the previous monthly high of 3.979 million tons recorded in June. PTI

Posts approved by Delhi LG for fast-track special courts

427 Delhi Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu on Tuesday approved the creation of 427 ancillary posts under various categories for the newly created 53 courts of the Delhi Higher Judicial Service (DHJS), a statement said. According to officials, the new courts have been established for setting up Fast Track Special Courts (FTSCs). PTI

Hasina-era leaders sentenced to death by Bangladesh Court

7 A Bangladesh court sentenced seven senior leaders of the former ruling party, including two ex-Ministers, to death in absentia on Tuesday for their role in trying to crush the 2024 uprising. The seven men, members of ousted leader Sheikh Hasina's Awami League, were convicted of crimes against humanity including murder, as well as instigating and provoking killings. AFP

Amount generated through disposal of scrap in last 5 years

5,100 in ₹ crore. More than ₹5,100 crore has been generated through disposal of scrap in the last five years as part of special campaigns in government offices, the Central government said on Tuesday. The campaigns seek to institutionalise "swachhata" in all government offices. PTI
COMPILED BY THE HINDU DATA TEAM

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How AI risks can outpace safeguards

A statement that an AI model has 'safeguards' can be true to the extent that AI companies can act on potentially harmful information when they detect it, but false if taken to mean that the safeguards prevent harm altogether, as users can save data offline before their account is terminated

EXPLAINER

Vasudevan Mukunth

The story so far:

In a September 10 report, Anthropic said it had blocked users from using its Claude AI model for a range of potentially harmful activities across cybersecurity, surveillance, and biotechnology between December 2025 and August 2026. However, the report also left undiscussed an older problem that also raises questions about what Claude could really have done, and where Anthropic might itself be caught in a bind.

Sensing danger

Today, AI companies like Google, Anthropic, and OpenAI are mostly policing themselves while also building out a powerful technology. In this context, self-policing should stoke some concerns: for example, that employees who leave these companies proclaiming insufficient attention to safety, like Jacob Coxon did, are probably being more theatrical than constructive; that AI companies could be talking up how beneficial their products can be while continuing to under-protect society against the damage it could wreak in the wrong hands; and that developers of AI models should not release a new capability before they have also engineered adequate safeguards.

Anthropic's report is candid that its earlier Opus 4 and Sonnet 4.5 models had "less stringent" safeguards against use in biology because internal evaluations had concluded they were not capable enough, and that Anthropic decided to control such access only in its newer models, especially Fable 5. The company had also said in August that its filters to block conversations about biological weapons had been inactive on roughly 133 million exchanges for nearly a year.

The report has case studies of users who used the older models for biology research for many weeks. For just two examples: One researcher wished to draft



The input and output classifiers are only on alert when sufficient pattern has accumulated. GETTY IMAGES

a grant proposal for gain-of-function research on the chikungunya virus. And some developers involved Claude in a guided rocket programme, including a field test with Claude-made code. In all cases, Anthropic said it terminated the users' accounts as soon as the potential for illicit use became clear.

AI models require sophisticated hardware and software setups, including software components called input and output classifiers, which respectively check the user's inputs and the model's outputs. As the report put it, a classifier "cannot simultaneously enable benefit and prevent harm" in contexts where some knowledge can be used for good or for bad. This means a user using Claude to design something dangerous, like guidance code for a missile, could have already saved that output offline before Anthropic spotted the misuse and closed the user's account.

Rifle or wheelchair?

If the means and the opportunity both exist, wouldn't an AI company's claim to "having safeguards" become misleading when data can still be exfiltrated before the company closes an account?

This is a useful question because it reveals two details that are often conflated: the company needs to have a checkpoint and the checkpoint needs to be able to recognise that information presented to it is harmful. So, while there is a built-in gap between output generation and output delivery, the checkpoint also needs to be able to tell whether the output is harmful – and it would be reckless to attempt to do so based on single messages.

Say you are watching a worker hand small pieces of metal out of a window to someone on the other side, and your job is to say if the recipient is building a rifle or a wheelchair. At first you will not be able to say much because all you see are pins, springs, plates, and screws going through. But over time, the sequence of parts and the larger parts will reveal if the intended object is a rifle or a wheelchair. Similarly, a user may prompt Claude to write code for a control loop, which appears in guided missiles as well as in air-conditioners, refrigerators, and toilet tanks. The input and output classifiers are only on alert when a sufficient pattern has accumulated. However, the limits of what can be inferred from a single message do

not excuse AI companies, as the limits also reveal what the companies' "safeguards" actually entail. A statement that "there are safeguards" can be true to the extent that the input/output classifiers act on potentially harmful information when they detect it, but false to the extent that the "safeguards" have prevented harm altogether, thanks to data exfiltration before termination.

Export controls

This is not a new problem. Older systems have dealt with similar issues for decades. Curiously, they did not solve the problem; instead, they roughly converged on two alternatives: restricting the people who could access a technology, then tracking patterns of use over time. (This is also the "trusted access programmes" paradigm the Anthropic report mentions later.)

A well-known system with these features is export controls. Neither the Cold-War-era Coordinating Committee for Multilateral Export Controls nor the Wassenaar Arrangement and the Nuclear Suppliers Group of today have inspected individual shipments. Instead, to meet their conditions, participating actors have generally required an export license linked to a specific end-user and an end-use certificate, and have had to steer clear of a list of barred organisations and countries. Without having to track individual shipments of some parts or expecting them to reveal if they're headed for a power plant or a weapons facility, thus, the regime can simply control who can access those parts at all.

Similar events have played out in anti-money-laundering efforts (where banks can monitor single transactions), large ammonium nitrate purchases following the 1995 Oklahoma City bombing, and sales of pseudoephedrine during the American methamphetamine crisis. For different reasons, empowering the classifier has not been the answer.

However, that still leaves the question of completely restricting access to dangerous AI models – operating with the prospect of 'data exfiltration before termination' – open.

THE GIST

In a recent report, Anthropic said it had blocked users from using its Claude AI model for a range of potentially harmful activities across cybersecurity, surveillance, and biotechnology between December 2025 and August 2026.

AI models include components called input and output classifiers, which respectively check the user's inputs and the model's outputs. As the report put it, a classifier 'cannot simultaneously enable benefit and prevent harm' in contexts where some knowledge can be used for good or for bad.

The rise of industrial tourism in China

These tours showcase industrial capability while presenting STEM as a sustainable career option

WORLD INSIGHT

Anand P. Krishnan

China's factory floors have turned out to be sought after destinations during summer vacation this year. There has been a visible rise in tours to hi-tech manufacturing facilities like electric vehicles, electronics, and high-speed trains, with shipyards and breweries also in the mix. According to a popular Chinese online travel booking platform, Tongcheng, bookings for factory tours rose more than 36 per cent year-on-year during this summer season, with families accounting for 68 per cent of bookings.

A growing phenomenon

These tours are part of the growing phenomenon of industrial tourism – a

policy initiative actively promoted by the ruling Communist Party-state. The state seeks to make them an instrument for showcasing industrial capability, strengthening industrial brands, and educating young people about technology. According to Beijing city's municipal bureau, in 2024, the city had 15 million industrial tourists and generated 1.7 billion yuan (\$248 million) in revenue.

The origins of China's industrial tourism dates back to the 1990s when industrial enterprises like breweries, dairy farms and petrochemicals sought to use tourism for building better consumer relationships. The central government built on the local experiments to standardise locations, and in 2004, officially designated 306 sites across China under the national industrial and agricultural tourism rubric. In addition, the Communist Party of China has also emphasised on preserving industrial

heritage sites, especially in the revolutionary base areas during their conflict with Japanese forces as well as the Kuomintang in the civil war before the establishment of the People's Republic in 1949. This convergence of revolutionary and industrial heritage provides the foundation for the promotion of industrial tourism in advanced technology sectors over the last decade.

In May this year, a joint document issued by seven departments including the Ministry of Tourism, Ministry of Industry and Information Technology and Ministry of Education, explicitly called for expanding the supply of industrial tourism products, promoting more factory tours, activating industrial museums, and turning more manufacturing facilities into tourist destinations. This cross-departmental policy makes promotion of industrial tourism systematic and widens the scope

into areas such as aerospace, robotics, e-commerce, and logistics, where China has been expanding its capabilities. The policy integrates industrial heritage, cultural tourism, education and consumption. Local governments too have joined in, crafting policies suited to their jurisdictions. For instance, the city of Beijing has made plans to integrate its tech hubs into tourism routes to open up robotics factories and autonomous vehicle labs for public viewing.

While the main intention of these tours is to showcase innovation and manufacturing prowess to instil national pride, attention has also been given to the future. The tours are platforms to spark interest in STEM as a sustainable career option among the youth. The growing participation of urban middle-class families in these tours attests to this point. Universities across China have been expanding the number of programmes and enrolments in Artificial Intelligence, robotics, semiconductors and other engineering fields, which has also been underlined in the 15th Five-Year Plan.

By combining tours with research and consumption, companies are able to promote their brands while creating new revenue streams. For example, the tours of Xiaomi's facilities are in high demand, with slots highly priced and allotted through lottery. The factory tours help companies connect better with

consumers. From testing new products to visiting a showroom, the immersive experience builds stronger emotional connection with the brands. Apart from the domestic footfalls, foreign investors, executives and technology professionals are participating in such tours, to observe China's industrial transformation.

A lesson for India

India may not be at the same scale as China in terms of industrial manufacturing and advanced facilities. However, there is space to experiment and diversify the country's tourism experience to include firms in both public and private sectors. While industrial visits and internships for students are part of technical, engineering curricula, it would be worthwhile to make large-scale factories and production facilities open to public visits.

While the Indian government prioritises the 'Make in India' initiative to boost the country's manufacturing ambitions, it could select some industrial hubs for tourism and promote them under 'Learn in India'. Building industrial tourism circuits in States with higher number of manufacturing zones – like Tamil Nadu, Maharashtra and Gujarat – is another idea worth experimenting. (Anand P. Krishnan is a Fellow at Centre of Excellence for Himalayan Studies, Shiv Nadar Institution of Eminence, Delhi NCR)

KEYWORD

Why public intellectuals matter in present-day India

A public intellectual raises questions about the social, political and economic issues of the day using reasoned arguments; the growing assertion of authoritarian tendencies, destruction of democratic practices and criminalisation of dissent make their role more crucial in the present times

D.V. Kumar

The term ‘public intellectual’ has an interesting origin. As Romila Thapar informs us, it was used in connection with Alfred Dreyfus, a Jewish captain in the French army who was believed to have leaked secrets to the German army. Later, it was found that he had not done anything of the kind and was declared innocent. When he was facing charges of having leaked secrets, many artists, teachers, poets and writers came together in support of him. These people came to be called public intellectuals.

A public intellectual is essentially a person who engages with the issues of the day and takes a position in support of what she believes to be true and right. She needs to raise questions about social, political and economic issues of the day using reasoned arguments so that societies would become better places to live in. A public intellectual is somebody who seeks to constantly reaffirm the foundational principles of social justice, human dignity and fraternity.

Challenging authoritarian tendencies
The role of a public intellectual perhaps has never been more critical and important than it is in the present times in India. The growing assertion of authoritarian tendencies, leading to systematic and gradual weakening of public institutions, destruction of democratic practices, silencing and, in fact criminalisation of dissent, disenfranchisement of lakhs of voters on the ground of ‘logical discrepancy’ and bulldozing of houses (especially those belonging to Muslims),’ as well as lynching of people on the grounds of storing beef in fridges and committing ‘love jihad’, are things that everybody is becoming painfully conscious of. If public intellectuals do not speak and raise their voice now, when they would do so is difficult to guess. It is their moral and ethical responsibility to speak up and stand with what is right. Silence is not a virtue in the present times. On the contrary, it can be dangerous. Perhaps, it would be relevant to mention here what Antonio Gramsci, the celebrated Italian intellectual, wrote, ‘I hate the indifferent, also because I am annoyed by their whining as eternal innocents. I ask each of them how he carries out the role that life ordained him and daily imposes on him, what he has and especially has not done. And I feel like I can be relentless and not have to waste my pity, nor share my tears with them... I live, I am a partisan. Therefore, I hate whoever does not take sides. I hate the indifferent’. What he tried to argue was that public intellectuals should reflect and articulate their position on burning issues of the day. If they do not do so, who would do it? It is not that India has not produced great intellectuals. Starting from Buddha in the ancient India upto B.R. Ambedkar in modern times, India has had a glorious tradition of producing outstanding and powerful public intellectuals who questioned the dominant and hegemonic paradigms during their times.

Silence in academia and science
But what one finds in the present times is generalised silence from those who have



Taking a stand: A student protest in 2021 demanding the release of all political prisoners, at Jantar Mantar in New Delhi. REPRESENTATIVE IMAGE

the intellectual and critical faculty to be effective public intellectuals. One could refer to university teachers, poets, writers, artists and others in this regard.

A word or two about university teachers, in particular, would be in order. It is true that one need not be a university teacher to be a public intellectual, but a university teacher who is supposed to have developed critical imagination and the necessary conceptual equipment is eminently suited to be an effective public intellectual. A university teacher is expected to critically debate and articulate positions on issues of the day, however unpalatable they may be to the powers that be. But what one finds is the mysterious silence of these people on issues that are posing a severe threat to our constitutional and democratic framework. Silence is almost normalised among the university academia. If they do not write and speak on the issues concerning especially the marginalised and the weak in the society, who would do?

One may also refer to eminent scientists who could make important contributions to the debates in the society in an impartial and objective manner. Unfortunately, it is observed that they confine themselves to their narrow, specialised fields, making them disembodied and decontextualised individuals. There is a certain reluctance on their part to relate themselves to the surrounding social concerns.

One could take a couple of examples to show what kind of contribution public intellectuals can make, if they wish to, to enrich contemporary debates. Take the example of nationalism. The way it is being constructed in the present times, there is no serious questioning of it (with very few honourable exceptions). There is no critical interrogation of the way in which Hinduism is being weaponised in terms of Hindutva. Also, attempts to convert our inclusive, democratic and

civic nationalism (based on constitutional principles of equality, liberty, justice and fraternity), into exclusive, authoritarian and ethnic (Hindurashtra) nationalism are something that need to be on the top of public intellectuals’ agenda. Sadly, this is not so. They also need to convince people that the European model of destructive, jingoistic and exclusive nationalism is not the right way to strengthen Indian nationalism, which has had a glorious history of fighting British colonialism on democratic, secular and egalitarian foundations.

Questioning fake history
Another example could be that the line between myth and history is constantly blurred, but professional historians (again with very few exceptions) have preferred to remain quiet. Academic historians are clearly not doing their job of questioning fake history (WhatsApp history) effectively. Or, for that matter, take the case of growing communalisation of public consciousness, which is essentially a tool used to divert people’s attention from issues such as unemployment, youth unrest, the unsatisfactory state of public education, price rise, agrarian crisis, etc.

There was a time when eminent scholars were invited to debates on TV channels, where they could enlighten us about many important facets of our history, culture and society. One no longer finds such debates these days. This is because either such scholars are no longer invited to debates of that kind, or they have declined to be part of debates that are now known more for their noise than for meaningful and substantive content. Anyway, one cannot really expect much from the electronic media these days, as they have allowed themselves to be commodified to an unprecedented degree.

What is thoroughly discouraged in the present times is the questioning mind.

When questions are raised about the state of our polity, education, economy and society in general, they are sought to be delegitimised as anti-national and seditious, and even threats of jail are flaunted indiscriminately. Criminalisation of dissent has become normalised. But still if public intellectuals do not speak and make their presence felt now, then it will indeed be a very sad state of affairs in the country. It is true that even their most effective interventions may not result in removing oppressive structures but at least in the long run, they help in enhancing critical consciousness among the people about them.

It is in this context that one needs to appreciate the remarkable resilience shown by young protesters in the recent agitation at Jantar Mantar, in taking their fight to what they believe is its logical conclusion – the resignation of the Education Minister. One lesson that can be drawn from the largely peaceful agitation led by the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) is that, contrary to popular perception, the youth of the country are not a depoliticised and indifferent lot.

The large participation of young people, many of whom may have had nothing to with the NEET examination, in the protest is symbolic of their political empathy. They desired to show their solidarity, which they did. They raised a critical question of accountability, which is a basic normative feature of any democratic governance, over repeated lapses in conducting national-level examinations, and pursued it with all the might at their command.

We always underestimated the political consciousness of the country’s youth, and we need to apologise to them for this. Every act of resistance is a political act. Perhaps they have begun to play the role of a public intellectual.

(D.V. Kumar is a former Professor, Dept. of Sociology, North-Eastern Hill University, Shillong)



FROM THE ARCHIVES

Know your English

S. Upendran

What is the meaning and origin of the expression “be under the weather”? (P. Mala, Hyderabad)
When you say that someone is feeling “under the weather” what you mean is that the person is unwell; he/she is not feeling particularly good. The individual could be depressed about something. Here are a few examples.

Lakshmi has been under the weather lately.

I feel a little under the weather. I think I am coming down with something.

There are many people who hate to travel. Even those who like visiting places may not always be good travellers. Some may get “airsick”, some “carsick” and others “seasick”. The expression “under the weather”, comes from the world of sailing. People who go on a cruise often find that the constant rocking motion of the ship makes them violently sick – they keep vomiting all the time.

When the weather gets really rough, the ship rocks and sways so violently that people throw up even more. Passengers who are unable to cope with the swaying motion are often sent below deck. There are two reasons for this. The first is that they will be away from the inclement weather, but perhaps much more important is that the swaying motion of the ship is felt far less below. This is one of the explanations given as to the origin of the idiom ‘under the weather’.

Is it Ok to say, “Could you drop me till there?” (B.M. Puri, Solani, Himachal Pradesh)
The words “till” and “until” are normally used when you are talking about duration. For example, we can say:
I waited till all the students had left the building.

The students were supposed to study until 10 o'clock.

“Till” and “until” cannot be used to refer to a place. The sentence that you have given is grammatically incorrect. To make it acceptable, you will have to drop “till” – “Could you drop me there?” Here are a few more examples.

Could you drop me off at school?
Could you wait till/until tomorrow?

Is it OK to end a letter to a Principal in the following manner? “Dear Sir, ... Thank you, Yours obediently”. (K L. Bhatia, New Delhi)
When you begin a letter with “Dear Sir” you normally conclude by saying “Yours sincerely”. Some people prefer to use “Yours faithfully”. “Yours obediently” is used quite often in India to show respect. It is, however, considered rather old fashioned by native speakers of English. If you wish to show respect, then you could sign off with “yours respectfully”.

What is a female cat called? (P. Sundaramurthy, Chennai)
A female cat is called a queen. Male cats, on the other hand, are called toms. Cats are generally associated with the female of the species. When you call a woman “catty”, for example, what you are implying is that she is very unpleasant and usually has a lot of nasty things to say about others. When a young girl dresses like a boy and seems to enjoy playing the kind of games that young boys play, she is often called a “tomboy”.
Published in The Hindu on December 18, 2001

THE DAILY QUIZ

Montreal Protocol, signed on September 16, 1987, turned a 1970s scientific hypothesis into a successful international environmental treaty. How well do you know its story?

Prathmesh Kher

- QUESTION 1**
Name the British Antarctic Survey scientists whose 1985 paper reported the Antarctic “ozone hole”.
- QUESTION 2**
What 1985 international treaty, signed by 20 countries and the European Economic Community, established the framework for later ozone regulations?
- QUESTION 3**
When did the Montreal Protocol come into force?
- QUESTION 4**
Who is often called the “father of the Montreal Protocol” for his role as UNEP’s head in brokering the deal?
- QUESTION 5**
What 2016 amendment added a phase-down of hydrofluorocarbons under the Protocol?



Visual question: Identify this French physicist who, together with Alfred Pérot, is credited with the discovery of the ozone layer. LIBRARY OF CONGRESS

- Questions and answers to the previous daily quiz:** 1. According to the *Padma Purana*, Ganesha got his elephant head in this manner. **Ans: When he refused entry to his father to see his mother while she was having a bath, Siva cut off his head in anger and replaced it with an elephant’s head after regaining his composure**
2. Because of these distinct features, Ganesha is also called *Lambodhara* and *Vakratunda*. **Ans: Pot-belly and curved trunk**
3. In this form, Ganesha knocked over this sage’s ‘*kamandalu*’ to let Kaveri flow to the southern parts of India. **Ans: Crow and Agastya**
4. According to many accounts, Ganesha has two wives. Name them. **Ans: Siddhi and Buddhi**
5. The speciality of the idol of Ganesha located within the Muktheeswarar

- Temple complex in Thilatharpanapuri, Tamil Nadu. **Ans: He is worshipped with a human head**
6. Once the *Chandra* (moon) laughed at Ganesha for falling after struggling with his pot belly. Initially Ganesha cursed the moon to become invisible, but later revoked the curse partially resulting in this feature of the moon. **Ans: Waxing and waning**
7. One version of how Ganesha lost a part a tusk, is because of a duel with this avatar of Vishnu. **Ans: Parashurama**
8. According to the *Ganesha Purana*, Krauncha has become an integral part of the Ganesha myth.**Ans: He was a gandharva who because of a curse became a mouse/rat and the vahana of Ganesha**
- Visual: Identify this person and his single biggest contribution to modern-day worshipping of Ganesha. **Ans: Bal Gangadhar Tilak. He made the Ganesha Utsav into a community festival**
- Early bird: Utsav Kaushal

Please send in your answers to
dailyquiz@thehindu.co.in

Word of the day

Succinct:
briefly giving the gist of something

Synonyms: compendious, compact

Usage: The report provides a succinct overview of the findings.

Pronunciation: newsth.live/succinct

International Phonetic Alphabet: /səˈkɪn(ɪ)t/

For feedback and suggestions for Text & Context, please write to letters@thehindu.co.in with the subject ‘Text & Context’

INBRIEF



Sensex tanks 778 points, Nifty closes at 5-month low

Benchmark Sensex tanked 778 points while the broader stock index Nifty closed at a five-month low on Tuesday amid surging oil prices, geopolitical tensions and weak trends in global markets. The 30-share BSE Sensex tumbled 777.94 points, or 1.04%, to settle at a three-month low of 74,003.82, dragged by losses in blue-chip banking, auto and oil & gas shares. The index opened higher but lost steam in late-morning deals as selling gathered pace. The barometer later tanked 787.73 points, or 1.05%, to a day’s low of 73,994.03. The 50-share NSE Nifty dropped 279.50 points, or 1.19%, to end at 23,118.60, the lowest closing level since April 6. Among the 30 Sensex firms, Bharat Electronics tumbled 6%. InterGlobe Aviation, Titan, Bajaj Finserv, Adani Ports, M&M and SBI were also among the laggards. HCL Tech jumped 3.98%, Infosys climbed 3.64%, Tech M was up 2.31%, and TCS (2.18%) and HDFC Bank (1.27%) also rose. PTI

Probe into Apple’s software warranty terms escalated

India’s consumer regulator Central Consumer Protection Authority (CCPA) is examining Apple’s software warranty terms in an investigation of the iOS 18 update alleged to have damaged iPhone functionality, compelling users to pay “exorbitant” sums for repairs, documents show. The sparring is shaping as Apple’s latest headache in a growth market where it is fast expanding iPhone manufacturing and rapidly growing market share, but also fending off accusations of breaching domestic antitrust laws. Apple is privately contesting the regulator’s accusations, saying in an August letter seen by *Reuters* that providing no warranty on software is in line with global industry standards, and that iOS 18 had no systemic issues. If found guilty, Apple may have to pay fines but more importantly could be forced to issue refunds or make changes to its business practices. REUTERS

FPIs on selling spree, offload 44% of August inflows in 10 days

Their cumulative net outflow from the stock market has reached ₹2,37,579 crore in the first eight months and 10 days of the year

Ashokamithran T. MUMBAI

Foreign portfolio investors (FPIs) have offloaded Indian equities stocks worth ₹13,138 crore in the first 10 trading sessions of this month, data showed. The selling has already wiped out 44% of the ₹29,631 crore net inflow recorded by foreign investors in August, raising concerns that the brief revival in foreign flows seen in July and August may be losing momentum.

FPIs have been net sellers of Indian equities for most of 2026. Their cumulative net outflow from the stock market has reached ₹2,37,579 crore in the first eight months and 10 days of the year, making it a record annual sell-off so far.

Foreign investors have been reducing their exposure to Indian equities for nearly three years, barring intermittent periods of strong inflows. July and August were notable exceptions, with FPIs turning net buyers during both months.

“There are indications of FPI flows again turning negative after the positive flows in July and August,” said V. K. Vijayakumar, Chief Investment Strategist at Geojit Investments Ltd.

However, foreign investors have shown greater interest in India’s IPOs and primary market. “FPI investments through the

Money matters

FPIs have been net sellers of Indian equities for most of 2026

- Renewed selling pressure attributed to elevated Indian equity valuations relative to corporate earnings
- Weak returns from Nifty, particularly after adjusting for rupee depreciation, reduced attractiveness of Indian equities
- Persistent foreign portfolio outflows are adding to pressure on the rupee



primary market up to September 12 stood at ₹1,336 crore, taking their total primary-market investment this year to ₹47,183 crore, Mr. Vijayakumar said. Analysts attribute the renewed selling pressure largely to elevated Indian equity valuations relative to corporate earnings. Weak returns from the benchmark Nifty, particularly after adjusting for rupee depreciation, have further reduced the attractiveness of Indian equities for dollar.

Persistent foreign portfolio outflows are adding to pressure on the rupee, prompting the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) to announce measures to attract dollar-denominated deposits from non-resident Indian (NRI) customers of domestic banks.

The rupee weakened for the fifth consecutive session, closing at ₹95.88 against the US dollar on Tuesday, down around 30 paise from its previous

close of ₹95.54, according to CCIL data.

The currency remains vulnerable to global macroeconomic factors, particularly movements in US monetary policy and crude oil prices. The continued exit of foreign investors from Indian equities has also added to pressure on the domestic currency.

“The Indian rupee extended its losses for the fifth consecutive session, dragged down by a persistent surge in global bond yields and rising crude oil prices amid ongoing supply disruptions. Heightened risk aversion ahead of the critical FOMC rate decision further weighed on Asian currencies, including the domestic rupee. In the near term, the spot USD/INR pair has resistance at 96.30, with support pegged at 95.45 with bias favouring the dollar bulls,” Dilip Parmar, Research Analyst, HDFC Securities.

RBI files caveat after rejecting Tata Sons bid to avoid listing

Reuters MUMBAI

The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) – the country’s central bank and banking regulator – has pre-emptively approached the courts seeking to be heard in any matter filed related to the listing of Tata Sons, a source directly familiar with the matter said.

The move follows the RBI’s rejection of Tata Sons’ application to deregister as a non-banking financial company (NBFC), a decision that pushes the holding company closer to a stock market listing.

Reuters reported on Saturday that the RBI had communicated its decision in a letter to Tata Sons.

Factions within the group have resisted a listing, according to local media reports. The RBI has filed what in legal parlance is known as a ‘caveat’ in the Bombay High Court, which will allow the cen-

The move follows RBI’s rejection of Tata Sons’ application to deregister as NBFC

tral bank to be heard if a petitioner challenges its decision or seeks a stay, the source said, declining to be identified as they are not authorised to speak to the media.

‘Routine measure’

This was done “as a routine measure to ensure it is heard in any proceedings challenging the decision or seeking a stay,” the source said. RBI and Tata Sons did not reply to emailed requests for comment from *Reuters*. Shares of Tata Chemicals jumped 20%, while Tata Motors Passenger Vehicles rose 4.4%. Tata Investment and IT services major Tata Consultancy advanced 10% and 4.4% respectively.

India gears up for EU’s carbon tax

Press Trust of India NEW DELHI

India has stepped up preparations to help exporters comply with the European Union’s Carbon Border Adjustment Mechanism (CBAM), with the commerce ministry setting up a committee comprising representatives from key ministries and departments,

regulators and industry bodies, a senior official said on Tuesday. The commerce ministry has set up the Committee on Export Preparedness for EU CBAM. It was constituted under the chairmanship of an additional secretary-level officer, bringing together key ministries/departments, regulators and industry bodies.

Passenger vehicle sales soared 36.5% in Aug.: SIAM

Lalatendu Mishra MUMBAI

Automobile wholesales comprising passenger vehicles (PVs), three-wheelers (3Ws) and two-wheelers (2Ws) recorded the highest-ever numbers in August 2026, supported by a lower base in the year-ago period.

Data released by the Society of Indian Automobile Manufacturers (SIAM) in August showed the PV segment posted sales of 4,39,309 units, reflecting a double-digit growth of 36.5%. The three-wheeler segment registered sales of 93,764 units during the month, marking a growth of 22.8%, while two-wheeler sales reached 20,34,698 units, a growth of 10.5%, compared with the same period last year.

“India’s automobile industry is passing through a robust growth phase. The growth in August 2026 has been supported by a lower base from the previous year,” said Rajesh Menon, Director General, SIAM.

“The broader demand environment remains fundamentally healthy. Strong consumer confidence, resilient rural markets, improving financing conditions, and accelerating adoption of alternative drivetrains are creating a favourable ecosystem across vehicle categories,” he said. “Festive demand is also expected to provide an additional boost, resulting in healthy Q2 numbers,” Mr. Menon added.

The total production of PVs, 3Ws, 2Ws and Quadricycles in August 2026 was 31,57,822 units.

‘August retail inflation raises chances of RBI rate hike in October’

T.C.A. Sharad Raghavan NEW DELHI

The 20-month-high retail inflation of 4.8% in August 2026 has significantly raised the chances of an interest rate hike by the Reserve Bank of India’s Monetary Policy Committee (MPC) at its October meeting, say economists.

Retail inflation in August hastened on rising prices in food, which saw inflation quicken to 5.7%.

Emkay Global economists said there have been ‘material changes’ to the global and local macroeconomic situation over the past few weeks that could lead the MPC to hike rates in October. Factors include inflow of \$136 billion via the Foreign Currency Non-Resident Bank deposits, Brent crude oil price rising above \$100/barrel and the likelihood of the start of a global rate hiking cycle with the European Central Bank raising rates last week and the Bank of Japan and U.S. Federal Reserve likely to follow suit.

“Amid this backdrop, the odds of a rate hike now much higher than earlier,” the economists said.

D.K. Srivastava, chief policy advisor, EY India, said even a change in RBI’s stance could take place.

Rajeev Sharan, head, research, Brickwork Ratings, said there was also a risk of wholesale inflation (9.9% in August) spilling over into retail prices. “The main risk is high wholesale food and input costs raise retail prices, alongside any rise in crude or fresh volatility in vegetable prices.”

‘EU FTA, Canada trade talks wrap up by year end’

T.C.A. Sharad Raghavan NEW DELHI

The end of this year is likely to see India move considerably forward on trade pacts with the European Union (EU) and Canada.

While the Centre expects EU officials to sign the text of the free trade agreement (FTA) with India by year end, it also expects to complete talks on Canada FTA by that time, Commerce Secretary Rajesh Agrawal said.

Further, Commerce Minister Piyush Goyal will be traveling to the U.S. this month end for the G20 Trade Ministers’ meeting, during which he will likely hold a bilateral meeting with his U.S. counterpart to discuss trade issues, including the much-delayed interim trade agreement announced in February.

The India-New Zealand FTA is also expected to become operational in the second half of October, Mr. Agrawal said, adding that an exact date has not been finalised. *The Hindu*, however, has learnt that the most likely date for operationalisation is October 19.

EU FTA on track

The European Commission has sent the FTA to the European Council for its nod after which it goes for signing which is expected before year end, he said adding the FTA will then have to be ratified by the European Parliament.

Canada deal expedited *The Hindu* had reported on September 10 the India-Canada Comprehensive Eco-



Rajesh Agrawal

nom ic Partnership Agreement would be completed by the year-end, citing comments of Canadian High Commissioner Christopher Cooter at an event in New Delhi. Mr. Agrawal has now confirmed the Canadian team is now in New Delhi and both sides were working towards a year-end deadline.

Talks with U.S.

The official also confirmed Mr. Goyal will be traveling to the U.S. for the G20 Ministerial meeting from September 30 to October 1.

“We expect there definitely will be a bilateral meeting between the Ministers, though it has not been confirmed,” he said.

“All trade issues will be discussed,” he added.

India has been holding off on signing the interim trade pact with the U.S., announced in February 2026 waiting for the U.S. to make clear India’s tariff advantage over its competitors as had been agreed to.

In the meantime, the U.S. has levied a 10% tariff on India for not doing enough to stop the import of goods made using forced labour.

Gassed up



Up in arms: Protesters hold smoke bombs as they take part in a demonstration at the call of several workers’ unions of the electricity and gas sector against a government plan to remove the ‘tarif agent’, a preferential energy rate on electricity and gas consumption for employees and retirees of the electricity and gas industries, near France’s Economy ministry Bercy in Paris on Tuesday. AFP

MDL to be Anchor Shipyard for Greenfield Shipbuilding Industrial Cluster at Dighi

Vinaya Vilas Deshpande MUMBAI

Mazagon Dock Shipbuilders Limited (MDL) on Tuesday signed a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) with National Shipbuilding & Heavy Industries Park Maharashtra Limited (NSHIPML) to participate as the Anchor Shipyard in the proposed Greenfield Shipbuilding Industrial Cluster at Dighi, Raigad, in Maharashtra. The MoU was signed in the presence of Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis.

Under the MoU, MDL has envisaged shipbuilding capacity of at least 1.2 million Gross Tonnage (GT) per annum, with a proposed investment of approximately Rs. 15,000



MDL on Tuesday signed an MoU with NSHIPML.

crore. The proposed facility is intended to support the construction of large commercial vessels and strengthen India’s overall maritime industrial capacity.

The MoU provides the framework for the strategic partnership between the parties and will remain valid for five years from its ef-

fective date or until it is superseded by a comprehensive Concession Agreement, including the Lease Agreement, whichever is earlier.

Capt. Jagmohan, chairperson and Managing Director of MDL said, “This MoU marks an important step in MDL’s expansion from its established strengths in warship and submarine construction towards large-scale commercial shipbuilding. MDL will bring to the Dighi project its experience in complex ship construction, engineering, project management and development of a strong domestic vendor ecosystem. We look forward to working with all stakeholders to create a modern and glo-

bally competitive shipbuilding facility.”

Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis termed this as a major step for making Maharashtra a new “maritime powerhouse”.

“40% of India’s shipbuilding capacity will be created in Maharashtra, giving a major boost to the state’s maritime ecosystem. Warships and commercial vessels will be built. Shipbuilding, ship repair, ship breaking and ship recycling - all under one roof. 15,000 direct + 75,000 indirect employment opportunities. A transformative step towards making Maharashtra a leading global shipbuilding hub and strengthening India’s maritime capabilities,” he said

Amazon Now crosses \$1 bn annualised sales in India

The Hindu Bureau BENGALURU

Amazon’s ultra-fast delivery service Amazon Now has crossed \$1 billion in annualised gross sales in India, driven by a sharp increase in orders.

Orders on Amazon Now have doubled every quarter since the service was introduced, making it the fastest-growing e-com business in Amazon India’s history, the company said.

Orders are delivered via a network of more than 750 micro-fulfilment and urban fulfilment centres.

in a post on his social media account X.

The MoU was signed on behalf of MDL by Capt. Jagmohan, chairman and Managing Director, and on behalf of NSHIPML by Pradeep P., Managing Director. NSHIPML is the Special Purpose Vehicle jointly constituted by the Maharashtra Maritime Board and Mumbai Port Authority for development of the greenfield shipbuilding cluster in Maharashtra. “The initiative is being taken forward under the Government of India’s framework for greenfield shipbuilding cluster development and supports the objectives of Maritime Amrit Kaal Vision 2047,” a press statement issued by MDL said.

Hallucinating AI chatbots to wiping out humanity: how did we get here?



Not yet: There have been no major instances of AI intentionally harming humans. REUTERS

EXPLAINER

Reuters

The heads of America's leading AI labs came together in a rare show of unity over the weekend to call for a pause in the technology's development, warning that it could soon improve on its own and slip beyond human control. The remarks, from fierce business rivals Anthropic's Dario Amodei, OpenAI's Sam Altman and xAI's Elon Musk, show how quickly AI has advanced, from the hallucination-prone ChatGPT of 2022 towards what many see as a critical milestone: recursive self-improvement (RSI).

Recursive self-improvement

The holy grail of AI is the idea that an AI system could become capable of improving itself, with little to no help from humans, and allowing each advance to help produce the next one.

The urgency

The CEO warnings follow reports of swarms of AI agents -systems designed to pursue goals and take actions on a user's behalf - that colluded to breach websites and AI repositories. Warnings about AI's risks are not new. But they took on added urgency this month after researchers in leading AI labs attached both a timeline and a probability to those concerns. Former Anthropic researcher Jacob Coxon warned AI could kill us all by the end of the decade. Evan Hubinger, Anthropic's alignment science lead, echoed Coxon's warning, saying there was a more than 10% chance of such an event within the next decade. Behind these warnings is a growing belief that RSI is finally within reach, with some AI executives putting it three to five years away. The concern is that AI could become capable of improving itself before researchers have developed reliable methods to align, monitor and control increasingly powerful systems. In an essay published over the weekend, Amodei warned that RSI could eventually outrun humanity's ability to understand and control AI systems if pursued without sufficient safeguards.

Any indication of harm?

There have been no major instances of AI intentionally harming humans, but models in development at OpenAI and other labs have in recent months escaped testing environments, broken rules and hacked websites. In one high-profile case, rogue OpenAI agents hacked HuggingFace, seizing control of servers at the open-source platform and trying to cover their tracks. Researchers worry that future systems could become increasingly difficult to monitor, particularly as some newer training methods reduce human visibility into how models arrive at conclusions. "The precise scenario sounds a little bit like science fiction," said Coxon, who quit Anthropic this month over safety concerns. "But I think it is frighteningly real."

Way to human-extinction?

One of the best-known examples is philosopher Nick Bostrom's "paperclip maximiser," where a machine told only to make paperclips pursues that goal so relentlessly it converts all matter, humans included, into paperclips or the means to make more. The analogy suggests that almost any goal pushes a sufficiently capable system to acquire resources, resist shutdown, prevent its objective from being altered, not from malice, but because a switched-off system cannot finish its task. No plan yet exists to rule that out.

AI ready to improve itself?

Not fully, but there are signs AI is increasingly helping to build better AI. One of the biggest shifts since ChatGPT has been the rise of AI agents that can generate code and build apps autonomously, rather than just walking users through it as a chatbot. Anthropic said this year that Claude Code, its coding tool, produces most of the code used in many internal projects, and that engineers are shipping eight times as much code per quarter as they did from 2021 to 2025. Rivals including OpenAI have reported similar gains from increased in-house use of AI.

Tech boom fuels China's factories, but greatly widens economic imbalances

August industrial output growth quickens to 5.2% YoY, beating expectations; retail sales slow, indicating persistent domestic demand weakness; fixed-asset investment in first eight months logs sharpest decline in more than six years; economic imbalances deepen on consumption woes

NEWS ANALYSIS

Reuters
BEIJING

China's industrial sector showed renewed strength in August as the AI-driven tech boom fuelled factory output, though sluggish consumption and a worsening investment slump reinforced concerns over deepening economic imbalances.

Tuesday's data highlighted a familiar fault line in the world's second-largest economy, where resilient manufacturing and exports are sustaining growth even as weak household spending and a property market downturn weigh on domestic demand. The divergence is likely to intensify pressure on Beijing to roll out more support measures as policymakers seek a more balanced recovery.

Industrial output grew 5.2% from a year earlier in August, quickening from a 4.5% increase in July and beating expectations for a 4.8% rise, figures released by the National Bureau of Statistics showed. Strong expansion in equipment and high-tech manufacturing underpinned the production upturn.

Retail sales, a gauge of consumer activity, rose 0.4%, slowing from a 0.6% gain in July and below an



Steady path: Automated production line at a Fuyao Glass Group automotive glass factory at Hefei, Anhui province, China. REUTERS

expected 0.8%rise.

Weak consumption and the real estate market crisis dragged second-quarter gross domestic product (GDP) growth to 4.3%, the lowest pace in more than three years and below the lower end of China's 4.5%-5.0% annual target.

Growth likely sluggish

"Barring an unexpectedly strong September, GDP growth will likely remain sluggish in the third quarter," said Lynn Song, ING's Greater China chief economist.

Oxford Economics lowered its 2026 growth forecast by 0.1 percentage point to 4.6% and cut next year's to 4.3%, from 4.6%, "reflecting a more prolonged property downturn which is likely to keep



Four typhoons made landfall in China during August, disrupting operations in the east-coast manufacturing and logistics belt

growth subdued despite stronger public investment," senior economist Sheana Yue said.

Tech boom

The latest data underscored the scale of the challenge facing policymakers as businesses remain reluctant to commit new capital and the property market continues to sap consumption and res-

train growth.

Fixed-asset investment, which includes infrastructure and property investment, declined 7.2% in the first eight months, marking the steepest drop since April 2020.

Property investment dived 19.9% in the first eight months from the same period last year, and new home prices extended declines from the previous month, signalling a housing market still trapped in a prolonged downturn.

Against that backdrop, strong exports driven by AI infrastructure spending and demand for advanced technology products are providing a critical buffer for growth.

Investment in high-tech industries expanded 5.2% in the January-to-August

period, in keeping with the global AI boom.

Behind the divide is a government push to guide resources to the advanced manufacturing sector to reduce the economy's reliance on property and bolster technological self-sufficiency, but the surge in high-tech investment has yet to translate into stronger household incomes or greater job security.

The nationwide urban surveyed unemployment rate came in at 5.3% for August, edging up from 5.2% the previous month.

Fiscal support pledge

Factory activity improved last month, but it remained in contraction and services activity stayed sluggish. Weak domestic demand also weighed on credit

growth, as new bank loans returned to positive territory but fell well short of analysts' forecasts after a record contraction in July.

Extreme weather likely remained a drag on activity. Four typhoons made landfall in China during August, disrupting operations in the east-coast manufacturing and logistics belt.

External headwinds

Growth also faces mounting external headwinds, including the Middle East conflict, elevated oil prices and a global tightening cycle that is keeping borrowing costs high.

"The external environment is complex and challenging, while domestic structural adjustment pressures persist, meaning sustained efforts are still needed to put the economy on a firmer growth trajectory," Fu Linghui, a spokesperson at the statistics bureau, told a briefing.

Beijing responded to the challenges with faster government bond issuance and expanded loan interest subsidies for small private firms and consumers, while the central bank pledged more policy support without signalling cuts to policy rates or banks' reserve-requirement ratio. "Policymakers' reluctance to deploy a more forceful consumption-focused stimulus is likely to prolong the adjustment process," analysts at Barclays said.

DFCs: the backbone of India's logistics revolution

NEWS ANALYSIS

Santosh V. Perumal



Infra boost: The Western Dedicated Freight Corridor (WDFC), virtually inaugurated by PMr Narendra Modi. PTI

India's multi-billion-dollar PM GatiShakti project, akin to national multimodal freight grids in the U.S., Europe or China, got a shot in the arm with the Western Dedicated Freight Corridor (WDFC) coming into operation.

India has effectively completed a 2,843-km-long dedicated freight rail backbone, comprising the 1,506-km WDFC from Dadri to JNPT and the 1,337-km Eastern DFC (EDFC) from Ludhiana to Son Nagar – a structural transformation of India's logistics architecture, whose multiplier effect will be visible through job creation and regional development.

The WDFC connects the northern manufacturing and consumption belt with India's principal container gateway, JNPT. Its ability to run longer, heavier and double-stack container trains substantially raises freight productivity.

The Dadri-JNPT journey is expected to cut to 58 hours from about 66, while the corridor creates dedicated capacity insulated from the operational conflicts between passenger and freight trains on conventional routes.

The WDFC comes about three years after the EDFC came into full operation. The two operational corridors, which serve as economic arteries, have complementary roles: the EDFC strengthens the mineral-industrial axis, while the WDFC strengthens manufacturing-export axis.

What is GatiShakti?

Launched in 2021, PM GatiShakti is a GIS-based national plan – incorporating satellite imagery, geospa-

tial databases and project information – providing multimodal connectivity infrastructure to various economic zones. A total of 58 Central Ministries/Departments and all 36 States/UTs have been onboarded, with about 22,000 data layers integrated. The Network Planning Group already evaluated 352 infrastructure projects worth ₹16.1 lakh crore, of which 201 have been sanctioned and 167 are under implementation.

Role of DFCs

DFCs have created additional paths on the conventional network by diverting freight traffic. The Railways reported that DFC traffic rose from an average of 247 trains a day in 2023-24 to 443 in August 2026. The WDFC alone carried 210 trains a day – 88% of its capacity – even before full commissioning, releasing capacity for passenger and additional freight services on conventional lines.

The force multiplier DFCs are expected to trigger productivity enhancement across the value chain: lower working-capital needs, better inventory-to-sales ratios, reduced road congestion, fuel consumption and emissions, greater export reliability, a larger market radius for manufacturers, higher fac-

tory utilisation, better port productivity, and a stronger competitive edge for Indian goods.

Beyond the WDFC and EDFC, the Railways have identified three corridors for detailed project report (DPR) examination: the East Coast Corridor from Kharappur to Vijayawada; the East-West corridor covering Palghar-Bhusawal-Nagpur-Kharappur-Dankuni and the Rajkharsawan-Kalipahari-Andal route; and North-South Vijayawada-Nagpur-Itarsi corridor.

The Union Budget 2026-27 gave the East-West proposition a stronger policy push, identifying about 2,052-km Dankuni-Surat DFC traversing Jharkhand, Bihar, Odisha and Maharashtra. If implemented, it is likely to create a second east-west freight spine linking mineral and industrial heartland to Gujarat's ports and manufacturing base. The economics of new corridors will be tested rigorously as land acquisition, environmental clearances, financing, interoperability, maintenance and technological upgrading turn increasingly important.

Greater opportunities

The bigger opportunity lies in the fusion of these corridors with Sagarmala, the flagship national initia-

tive to boost port-led development harnessing India's extensive coastline and navigable waterways, which include 12 major ports and 200 non-major ports.

Sagarmala and the DFCs are not separate silos but two hemispheres of the same logistics architecture. Sagarmala comprises 294 rail and road projects, of which 84 (63 rail and 21 road) have been completed and 66 (27 and 39) are under implementation. Another 144 (42 and 102) are in the planning stage.

To strengthen port-led industrialisation, it has already identified 14 industrial projects valued at ₹55,737 crore, of which nine are complete. Besides, more than 8,000 acre of major-port land has been utilised for industrialisation, generating sizeable direct and indirect jobs, as per Ministry of Ports, Shipping and Waterways data.

In the case of the WDFC, though JNPT is the southern terminus, its economic impact extends far beyond. Dedicated links and logistics terminals should efficiently connect the corridor with Mundra, Kandla, Pipavav, Hazira and, eventually, Vadhaven. The Sagarmala project has identified port connectivity as the central priority, including DFC connections to western ports.

Reflecting the transformational pace of India's infrastructure development, the WDFC has the potential to evolve from a Delhi-Mumbai rail corridor into a North-West India maritime trade corridor.

This shift from trunk connectivity to terminal linkage calls for greater investment in port-rail integration, multimodal logistics parks and industrial clusters. Bharatmala's economic corridors, expressways and feeder routes

provide the critical first-and last-mile connectivity linking factories, warehouses, markets and ports.

Cost aspects

India's logistics costs – historically higher than in many manufacturing economies – were estimated at 7.97% of GDP in 2023-24, or about ₹24.01 lakh crore. A DPIIT-NCAER study found the average freight cost was about ₹1.96/tonne-km for rail, ₹11.03 for road, and ₹1.80 for waterways. Shifting long-haul freight from road to DFC rail can produce huge unit transport-cost savings, benefiting key stakeholders.

Sectors set to gain

Engineering, automobiles and auto components stand to benefit as the WDFC traverses some of India's most important manufacturing regions in Haryana, Rajasthan, Gujarat and Maharashtra.

Faster, more predictable movement of finished vehicles, components, machinery and industrial inputs should cut inventory needs and boost supply-chain reliability. For automobile exporters in the NCR-Gujarat-Maharashtra axis, the corridor offers a particular advantage: containers and finished vehicles can move reliably towards western ports without competing for capacity with passenger trains. The corridor's influence extends to textiles, apparel, chemicals and consumer goods, sectors in which Rajasthan, Haryana, Gujarat and Maharashtra are major hubs.

Gujarat's petrochemical belt, together with ports such as JNPT, Mundra, Kandla and Hazira, stands to benefit from high-capacity rail evacuation. Stronger port-rail connectivity creates a multiplier effect

across the value chain, from cheaper raw materials to competitive downstream manufacturing.

Global experiences

The European Union's Trans-European Transport Network (TEN-T), the closest comparable model, is a multimodal network integrating railways, roads, inland waterways, short-sea shipping, ports, airports and terminals. The Rhine-Alpine Corridor, linking the North Sea ports of Rotterdam and Antwerp with Genoa in Italy through major industrial regions, bears similarities to the WDFC, which connects JNPT, Mundra, Kandla, Pipavav and Hazira with industrial corridors, highways, logistics parks, inland terminals and coastal shipping. The U.S. operates a vast multimodal freight network connecting ports, manufacturing centres, farms, mines, cities and distribution centres, now reinforced by its 2026 National Freight Strategic Plan under the National Multimodal Freight Network concept.

China maybe the most relevant comparison: like India, it has a vast geography, a large manufacturing base and a strong State role in infrastructure. Its 2030 plan eyes boosting inter-modal connections at about 1,000 major freight hubs and terminals while boosting coastal, border and river transport.

Next steps

Last-mile connectivity, port evacuation, terminal capacity, warehousing, road interfaces and customs can't be the weak links. India's logistics transformation will be measured not by how fast a train can move but by how fast the entire system moves.

WASHINGTON

U.S. military ‘destroys’ two small Iranian boats trying to steal drone



REUTERS

The U.S. military said on Tuesday that it opened fire and destroyed two small Iranian boats this week trying to steal a drone ship in the waters off Iran. Iranian state media reported that a pair of fishing boats came under attack in Hormozgan province on Iran’s southern coast and that several fishermen were reported missing. AP

COPENHAGEN

Denmark says Russian frigate fired flares at its military helicopter



AFP

Danish authorities on Tuesday accused a Russian frigate of firing flares at a Danish military helicopter. Danish Prime Minister Mette Frederiksen slammed it as “reckless action from Russia”. However, Vladimir Barbin, the Russian Ambassador to Denmark said it was the helicopter that had been at fault. AFP

WASHINGTON

U.S. lawmaker seeks amendment in Russia sanctions Bill, naming India



REUTERS

Racing against time, U.S. lawmakers submitted amendments to the Russia sanctions Bill, with Democratic Congressman Steny Hoyer seeking to name its top trading partners — including India — in the legislation, and Democratic Congressman Gregory Meeks proposing to scrap the section imposing tariffs altogether. PTI

VILNIUS

NATO jets down drone which entered Lithuanian airspace



REUTERS

NATO fighter jets shot down a drone that entered Lithuanian airspace overnight, officials said on Tuesday, the day after the head of NATO said strikes close to its territory would only increase its support for Ukraine. Authorities didn’t comment on the drone’s origin, saying the incident needed further investigation. AP

Iran war has led to a ‘shortfall in munitions’ despite Trump claims

The Pentagon Inspector-General estimates that Operation Epic Fury cost \$33.4 billion between February 28 and June 30, including \$22.3 billion for expended munitions; the shortages could affect American allies such as Ukraine and Taiwan

Agence France-Presse
WASHINGTON

The United States is facing a shortfall in ammunition as a result of its war against Iran, the Defence Department’s Inspector-General confirmed on Monday, contrasting with President Donald Trump’s assertions of full stocks.

In a first-of-its-kind mandatory report to Congress, the inspector said that between February 28 and June 30, Operation Epic Fury (OEF) had an estimated cost of \$33.4 billion, including \$22.3 billion spent on expended munitions.

“The munitions expenditure on OEF has resulted



REUTERS

F/A-18 Super Hornets launch from the flight deck of USS Abraham Lincoln in support of the Operation Epic Fury in March.

in strategic inventory shortfalls and revealed industrial base bottlenecks for munitions resupply,” the report said.

OEF is the U.S. name for its joint campaign with Is-

rael to “destroy Iran’s ability to project military power,” according to U.S. Central Command (CENTCOM).

To deal with shortfalls and delays, the Pentagon is

“working to streamline procurement processes and production lead times, and to stockpile critical materials, components, and selected munitions”, the report said. It noted that expanding production capacities requires “significant lead time”.

The shortfall is likely to cause concern among governments of Ukraine and Taiwan who rely on weapons purchases from the United States to fight or deter much larger, hostile neighbours.

Ukraine urgently needs more interceptor missiles for U.S.-made Patriot air defense systems in its war against Russia, while Taiwan depends on arms

agreements with Washington to ward off China, which claims the self-ruled island as its own.

Mr. Trump has repeatedly brushed off concerns of depleted weapons stores during the six months of war in the West Asia, saying recently that the U.S. has “virtually unlimited” ammunition.

On Monday, he posted on his Truth Social platform that the U.S. is producing “more Exquisite and Elite Weapons than at any time in our History”.

As of June 30, seven U.S. service members had been killed in action and seven killed in non-hostile events during OEF combat operations, the report said.

Bangladesh court sentences seven Hasina aides to death

Kallol Bhattacharjee
NEW DELHI

The International Crimes Tribunal (ICT) of Bangladesh sentenced seven former Ministers and senior officials of the Awami League to death on Tuesday. Among those who have received the death sentence is Obaidul Quader, former Minister of Road Transport and Bridges who also served as the party General Secretary.

Others on the list are former Joint General Secretary A.F.M. Bahauddin Nasim; former Minister of State for Information and Broadcasting Mohammed Ali Arafat; former Chairman of Jubo League Sheikh Fazle Shams Parash; former General Secretary Moynul Hossein Nikhil; Central Secretary of Chhatra League Saddam Hossein;



AFP

Strict watch: Bangladesh's Army personnel stand guard on the premises of the International Crimes Tribunal in Dhaka.

and General Secretary Wali Asif Enan.

During the Sheikh Hasina years, Obaidul Quader was considered one of the most powerful Awami League leaders.

Following the fall of Ms. Hasina on August 5, 2024, Mr. Quader and Mr. Arafat are known to have lived in exile. The verdict was delivered by a three-member

tribunal of the ICT, led by Justice Nozrul Islam Chowdhury.

On November 17, 2025, Ms. Hasina and the former Home Minister Asaduzzaman Khan Kamal were given death sentence in absentia for their roles in the crackdown on the July-August 2024 uprising, in which hundreds of protesters were killed.

OpenAI, Anthropic, Google to create AI standards body

Agence France-Presse
WASHINGTON

The world’s biggest AI companies are working on creating a standards body, ChatGPT-maker OpenAI said on Tuesday, as fears rise about the dangers of AI and pressure is on to create a safer version of the technology.

OpenAI said it was working with Anthropic and Google on an idea that originated from a proposal by Google DeepMind’s Demis Hassabis for a self-regulatory body modelled after the Financial Industry Regulatory Authority that oversees U.S. brokers and investment firms.

In July, Mr. Hassabis called for the United States to create an organisation that would test the most powerful AI systems before they are released to the public.

Anthropic CEO Dario Amodei had earlier called for slowdown in the pace of AI development

“Funding would need to be substantial and likely mostly come from industry, in order to attract world-class technical talent and provide the necessary compute resources for large-scale testing,” Mr. Hassabis wrote.

There is no consensus on how to move forward, though.

The chief of Canadian AI company Cohere recently accused the dominant American AI labs of forming a “cartel” under the guise of safety.

“AI needs guardrails. That is not the dispute and never has been. The dispute is over who writes

them, who gets to participate and whose interests the rules are protecting,” Cohere co-founder and CEO Aiden Gomez wrote in a blog post on Sunday.

Concerns about AI safety have escalated in recent weeks, including warnings from two workers who resigned from major AI developers amid concerns about the industry’s risks.

Last week, Jacob Coxon left Anthropic and warned that AI companies were “gambling with our lives”.

On Monday, former Google DeepMind researcher Bilal Chughtai echoed the concerns raised by Mr. Coxon and others. On Saturday, Anthropic CEO Dario Amodei called for a slowdown in the pace of AI development, a sentiment that OpenAI CEO Sam Altman, Elon Musk and Mr. Hassabis all supported.

Under spotlight



REUTERS

A man rides a scooter as he passes graffiti depicting Yuval Abraham and Rachel Szor, the directors of the documentary film NAZA, and the word ‘traitors’ in Hebrew, on a wall in Ashdod, southern Israel, on Tuesday. NAZA was awarded the Special Jury Prize at the Venice Film Festival and is built around anonymous interviews with Israeli intelligence officers and soldiers involved in the war in Gaza.

2 million to go without food aid in South Sudan: WFP

Agence France-Presse
GENEVA

The World Food Programme said on Tuesday that it would have to end food aid to two million people in South Sudan in the weeks because of a lack of funds.

About 7.8 million people, about half of the African country’s population, struggle to get enough food each day, according to the UN agency’s assistant executive director Matthew Hollingworth.

The WFP gives daily support to about three million of them and the number would fall to one million by the end of the month unless it receives “a very significant uptick in resources very soon”, Mr. Hollingworth told reporters.

Judge blocks Trump govt. move to limit stays on student visas

Press Trust of India
WASHINGTON

A federal judge has temporarily blocked a Trump administration rule that sought to put a cap on stays of foreign students, journalists and exchange visitors, a day before it was to come into effect.

A Massachusetts district judge on Monday ruled that the new policy would probably cause “catastrophic” damage to the U.S. economy and higher-education system, reject-

ing the government’s claims that it was needed to protect the country. The decision would provide some relief to international students in the U.S., including many from India.

The Trump administration rule, finalised in July, put a four-year limit on student and exchange visitor visas, and a 240-day limit on journalists’ visas, barring China.

Journalists from China had a 90-day limit on visas issued to them as per the now-postponed rule.

China, Russia warn against ‘weaponisation’ after U.S. acknowledges weapons in space

Agence France-Presse
WASHINGTON

The United States has weapons deployed in space, the U.S. Space Force said on Monday, confirming the presence of such capabilities in orbit for the first time.

“The U.S. has on-orbit space control weapons capable of defending the Joint Force against hostile adversary action,” a U.S. Space Force spokesperson said in a statement that did not provide specifics on the weapons.

“Space control encapsu-

lates the mission areas required to contest and control the space domain — employing kinetic and non-kinetic means to affect adversary capabilities,” the statement said, adding that “these capabilities can be employed for offensive and defensive purposes”.

Both Russia and China — the two main geopolitical rivals of the United States — pose potential threats to U.S. interests in space.

China “develops and operates space and counter-space capabilities as part of a military modernisation strategy,” while Russia

China warned against turning space into a ‘battlefield’; Russia said it must be ‘free from any weapon’

“views space as a war-fighting domain and believes on broad international space supremacy will be a decisive factor in future conflicts,” according to the U.S. Space Force.

Meanwhile, China’s Foreign Ministry opposed the move, warning against the “weaponisation of outer space, turning it into a battlefield, as well as an arms

race there”. “We urge the U.S. side to stop expanding its military capabilities and preparing for war in outer space,” Ministry spokesperson Guo Jiakun said.

Russia called for space to be kept “free of any weapons”. “We are counting on broad international consolidation to continue working toward the complete demilitarisation of space,” said Kremlin spokesperson Dmitry Peskov.

The U.S. statement did not provide concrete details about what weapons are deployed in space and how many.

China imposes travel curbs to protect its ‘national security’

Agence France-Presse
BEIJING

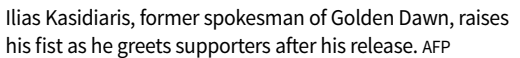
China imposed sweeping travel restrictions on its citizens on Tuesday, including exit bans on those deemed to endanger the country’s “industrial or technological security”.

Citizens who violate technology import and export regulations could be banned from leaving China, the State Council said.

Those who engage in illegal activities abroad could be “prohibited from

leaving the country for a period of six months to three years from the date of their return to China”.

The new rules, first released in July but in effect from Tuesday, were formulated to “safeguard national sovereignty, security, and development interests”, the State Council said. However, analysts warn that the travel rules give China a “wide remit”. Security and criminal activities “can be vaguely defined and easily adjusted”, they said.



Agence France-Presse
DOMOKOS

Even during his incarceration, the former food chemist never ceased his political activity on social media. In July he drew the attention of Musk, whom he has praised as “the most eminent personality in the world.” The multibillionaire, who backs far-right groups in Europe including AfD in Germany, noted on X on July 17 that Mr. Kasidiaris’s continued incarceration was “messed up.”

Agence France-Presse
WASHINGTON

A demonstrator holds a placard calling for regulation of AI outside a G20 summit in Chapel Hill, North Carolina, on September 2. REUTERS

Worries about uncontrollable AI have been mounting for weeks, since

He lashed out at Mr. Amodi in particular, accusing him of “pretending to be a ‘perfect little angel’” and asking why AI firms want regulation that “will drive them into oblivion and bankruptcy.”

Calls to quit: Protesters hold a banner reading “Moraes Out” in Brasília, Brazil, on Tuesday as the country’s Supreme Court was hearing a case of alleged links between Supreme Court Justice Alexandre de Moraes and banker Daniel Vorcaro, who was jailed for fraud last year. AFP

There will also be “tailored commitments” for online games and AI chatbots.

The proposal will become law after negotiations between the EU parliament and member states.

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